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# Trusted Services Marketplace

## KENYA · STRATEGIC BLUEPRINT AFTER THE PIVOT

Whatever you need done, find someone you can trust. A blueprint for a services marketplace built on verified people, protected payment, and an evidenced record of completed work.

### THE THREE FINDINGS THAT RESHAPE THIS PLAN

- 1 Two funded companies already tried this in Nairobi. Lynk** (2015–2022) connected households with verified fundis, artisans and domestic workers across dozens of categories; it pivoted operating models repeatedly, abandoned its auction model, and exited by acquisition. **SweepSouth** raised over \$15M and left Kenya in November 2022. Horizontal is how they failed, not how they grew.
- 2 The KSh 5,000 line.** No service with a median transaction below roughly KSh 5,000 can support a transaction fee that also pays for human trust operations. This eliminates *mama fua*, cleaning and errands by arithmetic — most of the launch list in the brief.
- 3 There is a stronger wedge.** Kenya received **US\$5.04bn** in remittances in 2025, and diaspora buyers are defrauded precisely because distance makes due diligence impossible. Be someone's trusted eyes and hands in Kenya when they cannot be there themselves — high value, structurally leakage-resistant, and unserved.

FACT

RECOMMENDATION

ASSUMPTION

LEGAL — COUNSEL REQUIRED

Every claim in this document is tagged **FACT** (verified and cited), **RECOMMENDATION**, **ASSUMPTION** (unverified), or **LEGAL — COUNSEL REQUIRED**. All sources are listed in the final section.

Research conducted **08 September 2026** · 17 sections · Covering all 69 sections of the brief

**This document is not legal, tax, or financial advice.** Regulatory sections identify areas requiring professional Kenyan counsel.

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# Executive Thesis and the Honest Verdict

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**Status:** strategy, built on desk research conducted 8 September 2026. Claims are tagged **FACT** (verified, cited in [sources.md](#)), **REC** (recommendation), **ASSUMPTION** (unverified belief requiring validation), and **LEGAL — COUNSEL REQUIRED**. Nothing here is legal, tax or financial advice.

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## 1. You asked me to challenge you. Here is the challenge.

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**Your diagnosis is right. Your prescription is the single most attempted and most failed business model in African consumer tech, and two well-capitalised companies have already run this exact experiment in Nairobi.**

**FACT Lynk.** Founded in Nairobi in 2015 by Adam Grunewald and Johannes Degn. It connected households and businesses with *verified domestic workers, fundis, artisans and blue-collar professionals in Nairobi*, across dozens of categories — furniture, beauty, installation, repair, maintenance. That is your pivot, built a decade ago. Lynk **pivoted its operating model multiple times** searching for one that could deliver a services marketplace at scale in Nairobi. Its defining early question was whether to be *lead-gen* or *full-service*. Vetting and training costs were high enough that it had to build its own **Lynk Academy** after vocational-training partnerships failed. It also hit a problem no product spec anticipates: customers, often from significantly higher social classes than the providers, **would unfairly mistrust tradespeople** — assuming cheating or poor quality — from prior bad experience or communication gaps. Lynk was acquired by Nigeria's Eden Life in 2022. ([The Flip](#), [Jobtech Alliance](#), [WeeTracker](#))

**FACT SweepSouth.** South African home-services platform, founded 2014, **backed by over \$15 million**. Entered **Kenya in 2019. Exited Kenya and Nigeria on 25 November 2022**, citing tough economic conditions; commentary at the time described the expansion as half-hearted with shoddy operational setup and delayed technology. It continues to operate in South Africa and Egypt. ([TechCabal](#), [Capital FM](#))

**FACT The successful African outcome was not a marketplace outcome.** Kandua, South Africa's home-services marketplace, raised **\$13M** and was **acquired by Santam — an insurer — in May 2024**, having built embedded financial services into the platform. ([PitchBook](#), [BFA Global](#))

**FACT The global picture is not encouraging either.** TaskRabbit was acquired by IKEA in 2017. Handy was acquired by ANGI and reportedly struggled to exceed a **2:1 LTV:CAC**. Lead-generation marketplaces show **repeat rates as low as 15%**. Airtasker, a listed transactional marketplace, did **AUD 52.7M revenue in FY2025** after more than a decade. The one unambiguous success — Urban Company — is **not a horizontal light-touch marketplace**: it is a *managed* marketplace that controls onboarding, training, equipment, pricing, scheduling and quality, because "the easy path of pure marketplace aggregation didn't work: supply quality couldn't be controlled." ([Airtasker FY26 call](#), [Oyelabs](#), [Arthnova](#))

**And the Kenyan field is not empty today.** **FACT** My-Fundi, Balozy, Kalinoi, Juakali Hub and Cleaner-Kenya are all operating. **Kalinoi already spans cleaning, caregiving, gardening, events, tech**

**repairs — and social-content creators.** Someone is already building the horizontal thing you described, creators included.

## 2. Separating the good idea from the dangerous one

Your brief contains two distinct propositions, and they have very different merit.

| Proposition                                                                           | Verdict                                                                                                                     |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| "One trust infrastructure, many service verticals" — a reusable transaction primitive | <b>Correct, and worth building.</b> This is a genuine architectural insight and it is cheap to honour from day one.         |
| "Launch a horizontal trusted-services marketplace"                                    | <b>Wrong, and it is what killed the predecessors.</b> Horizontal is a <i>destination</i> , not a <i>starting position</i> . |

The reason the second fails is not lack of ambition or execution. It is structural:

**Every service category is a different company.** Supply acquisition, vetting, pricing logic, quality control, seasonality, failure modes and safety risk are almost entirely different for a cleaner, a plumber, a house-hunter and a TikTok creator. What actually transfers between them is the payment rail and the reputation schema — **which are the cheap parts.** The expensive parts (finding and vetting good supply, standardising the service, controlling quality, resolving category-specific disputes) transfer almost not at all. You get the cost of five businesses and the liquidity of none.

## 3. The arithmetic that eliminates most of your launch list

From the earlier work: at KSh 10,000 average order, M-Pesa collection and payout consume 14-21% of platform revenue, and per-order human operations cost is the binding constraint. Applying that to the categories in your brief:

**ASSUMPTION** — cost inputs are my estimates and must be replaced with real quotes.

| Service                    | Typical price     | Fee @15%          | Payment cost | Gross        | Cost to serve  | Contribution        |
|----------------------------|-------------------|-------------------|--------------|--------------|----------------|---------------------|
| Errand / delivery          | KSh 800           | 120               | ~72          | 48           | 150-300        | <b>Negative</b>     |
| Mama fua / laundry         | KSh 1,500         | 225               | ~86          | 139          | 150-350        | <b>Negative</b>     |
| House cleaning             | KSh 3,000         | 450               | ~121         | 329          | 200-400        | <b>≈ Zero</b>       |
| <b>Fundi repair job</b>    | <b>KSh 8,000</b>  | <b>1,200</b>      | <b>~211</b>  | <b>989</b>   | <b>250-400</b> | <b>+600-740</b>     |
| <b>Property inspection</b> | <b>KSh 6,000</b>  | <b>1,200 @20%</b> | <b>~181</b>  | <b>1,019</b> | <b>250-400</b> | <b>+620-770</b>     |
| <b>UGC video pack</b>      | <b>KSh 22,000</b> | <b>3,300</b>      | <b>~381</b>  | <b>2,919</b> | <b>300-450</b> | <b>+2,470-2,620</b> |

## REC The KSh 5,000 line

No service category with a median transaction below roughly KSh 5,000 can support a transaction-fee marketplace that also performs human trust operations in Kenya. The payment rail and one support contact consume the entire fee.

This single constraint **eliminates errands, mama fua and standard cleaning as launch categories** — which is most of the list in sections 4 and 5 of your brief. Not because they lack demand. Because you cannot get paid for serving them.

**The counter-argument you should test:** Urban Company and SweepSouth serve low-ticket cleaning profitably at scale by *removing the per-order human cost entirely* through standardisation, and by raising basket size. That is a real path — but it is the **managed, capital-intensive, one-vertical** path, not the horizontal marketplace path. You cannot have both.

## 4. The frequency paradox — why home services has no sweet spot

This is the trap that is not obvious from the outside, and your brief walks straight into it in sections 24 and 25.

You treat recurring services as the prize: *"Book Mary every Saturday."* **REC** **Recurring, local, in-person, same-provider services are the highest-leakage transactions in any marketplace.** By week three the customer has Mary's number, Mary is in their home weekly, and both parties save 15% by using M-Pesa directly. There is no feature that survives this. The relationship *is* the disintermediation.

Meanwhile, the low-frequency categories (plumbing, moving, painting) have the opposite problem: the customer transacts twice a year, never forms a habit, and forgets you exist between jobs.

|         | HIGH FREQUENCY<br>(cleaning, mama fua) | LOW FREQUENCY<br>(plumbing, moving, painting) |
|---------|----------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| Habit   | Forms fast                             | Never forms                                   |
| Leakage | Near-total by job 3                    | Low                                           |
| AOV     | Below the KSh 5,000 line               | Above it                                      |
| Verdict | Great habit, no revenue                | Good revenue, no habit                        |

**REC** **The escape from the paradox is a third axis: transactions that are frequent enough to matter, high-value enough to pay for themselves, and structurally resistant to leakage because the customer cannot easily re-contract privately.** That combination does not exist in ordinary home services. It exists where **the buyer is remote**.

## 5. The wedge you did not ask about — and I think it is the strongest one

You asked: *"Is there a stronger wedge we haven't considered?"* Yes.

## Be someone's trusted eyes, hands and judgement in Kenya, when they cannot be there themselves.

**FACT** The market is real and large. Kenyan diaspora remittances reached **US\$5.04 billion in 2025**, with CBK projecting **US\$5.24 billion for 2026** (tracking at US\$4.96 billion for the 12 months to June 2026). ([Business Daily](#), [The Star](#))

**FACT** The trust deficit is documented, severe and worsening. Housing scams are surging in Nairobi's prime estates — Kilimani, Kileleshwa, Jamhuri, Lavington — with fraudsters exploiting Kenya's deposit convention by posing as landlords or agents, collecting deposits from multiple victims for one unit, and staging viewings of occupied houses with fake landlords. **Diaspora investors are targeted specifically because distance makes due diligence nearly impossible**; fraudsters register professional-looking companies with upscale Nairobi offices, doctored images and falsified land registration numbers. Reporting on protection concludes that **"having a trusted, verifiable representative in Kenya is one of the most effective protections you can have in a landscape where fraud thrives on distance and information asymmetry."** ([Citizen Digital](#), [Daily Nation](#), [Mwakilishi](#), [Huduma Global](#))

That sentence is a product specification written by a journalist.

### Why this wedge beats everything in your list

| Test                                | Home services    | Creator marketplace | Remote-principal services                      |
|-------------------------------------|------------------|---------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| AOV above the KSh 5,000 line        | ✗ mostly         | ✓                   | ✓                                              |
| Trust deficit worth paying to close | Moderate         | Low-moderate        | <b>Extreme, documented</b>                     |
| Disintermediation resistance        | ✗ very poor      | Moderate            | ✓ <b>strong — see below</b>                    |
| Buyer willing to prepay             | Uncertain        | ✓                   | ✓ <b>already sends money blind</b>             |
| Buyer's ability to pay              | KSh earners      | KSh earners         | ✓ <b>hard-currency earners</b>                 |
| Supply must be trained per category | ✗ yes, expensive | ✓ digital-native    | ✓ <b>largely fungible</b>                      |
| Completion verifiable remotely      | ✗ hard           | ✓                   | ✓ <b>photo/video/report is the deliverable</b> |
| Safety exposure                     | High (in homes)  | Low                 | Medium                                         |

**The disintermediation point is the important one and it inverts your section 27.** A diaspora customer cannot easily go around you, because *the thing they are buying is precisely the thing they lack*: a verified stranger they have no relationship with and no way to vet. Their WhatsApp network is not the competitor here — **their WhatsApp network is what is failing them**, and sometimes defrauding them. Repeat business runs through the platform because the platform is the guarantee, not the introduction.

**REC** **The entry service is property verification** — inspect this apartment before I send the deposit; view this house on my behalf; verify this land title and photograph the plot; confirm this developer's site actually exists. **REC** **It then extends along a natural line** — supervise a fundi doing repairs on my rental, collect and courier documents, check on my mother, attend a school meeting, verify goods before I pay a supplier, oversee a construction milestone — **without needing a newly trained supply pool for each**, because the underlying capability is the same: *a verified, accountable person who goes somewhere, observes carefully, documents it and reports honestly.*

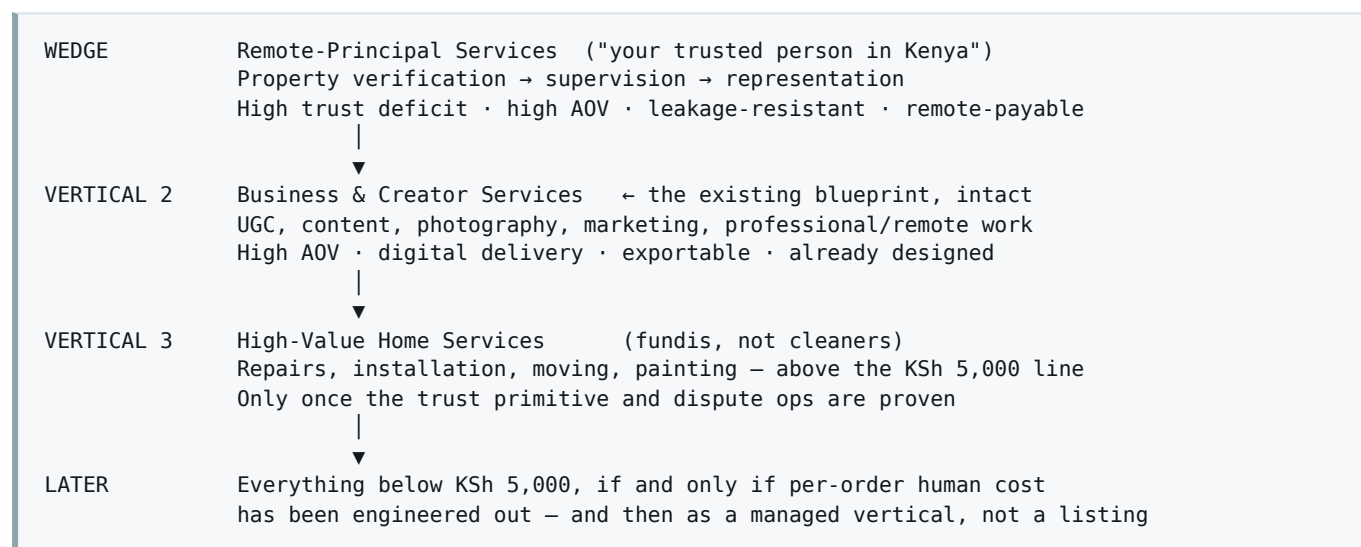
**REC** **And it has a recurring layer with real money in it:** diaspora Kenyans who own property need ongoing tenant vetting, rent-collection oversight, quarterly property checks and maintenance supervision. That is a monthly or quarterly relationship at a defensible price, with leakage resistance intact because the customer's whole problem is that they cannot supervise the supervisor.

## The honest weaknesses of this wedge

**ASSUMPTION** **I cannot verify how many diaspora Kenyans would pay for this, at what price, or how often.** No source I found sizes it. That is the single biggest open question and it is cheap to test — see `11-roadmap.md`. - Frequency for non-property-owners is low (perhaps 2-4 times a year). - **Agency risk is the hardest trust problem in this document.** You are dispatching someone to act on a remote principal's behalf, often near money. If your inspector can be bribed by the seller, the product is worthless. This is addressed in `06-trust-architecture.md` and it is not a solved problem. - It is a services business before it is a marketplace, and it will feel small for the first year.

## 6. What I recommend you actually build

**REC** **Three verticals, sequenced, on one shared transaction primitive. Not a horizontal marketplace.**



**REC** **Cleaning, mama fua and errands are not in the plan.** Not at launch, not in year two. They are the categories that killed the predecessors, they sit below the KSh 5,000 line, they leak fastest, and in the case of domestic work they carry employment-classification exposure — **FACT** Kenya's gazetted minimum wage for domestic workers is **KSh 18,047/month** in the major cities, and over two million domestic workers are employed informally, largely on verbal agreements. **LEGAL — COUNSEL REQUIRED** Placing domestic workers has a materially different regulatory profile from booking a plumber.

## 7. Is there a bigger company here than the creator marketplace?

**Yes — but not the company you described, and for a different reason than you gave.**

The creator marketplace was capped at roughly **\$200k-\$400k ARR in Kenya** because the measured influencer market is **FACT** US\$2.1M-3.0M. That cap is real.

The horizontal services marketplace is **not obviously bigger**, because it fails before it reaches scale: it has lower AOV, worse leakage, higher safety cost, five supply problems instead of one, and two funded predecessors who could not make it work in this exact city.

**What is genuinely bigger is the thing underneath both:** a verified record of who reliably does real-world work in Kenya, and a transaction rail that makes strangers safe to hire. **FACT** **The realised outcome for the best-run African example of this — Kandua — was acquisition by an insurer, after building embedded financial services.** That is a strong signal about where value in this category actually pools: **not in the take rate, but in what the transaction record makes possible.**

**REC** **But treat that as a destination, not a plan.** Your section 14 asks me to revisit "the ledger is the moat." Revised honestly: the ledger is a *consequence* of doing a narrow thing well for years, not a strategy you can execute toward. Anyone who builds for the ledger before they have liquidity builds neither. And **REC** — as your brief rightly cautions — lending, insurance and underwriting carry regulatory and risk analysis far beyond this document's scope, and must not appear in a fundraising narrative as though they were adjacent.

## 8. One correction to your trust model, because it matters everywhere downstream

Your section 10 says a provider's reputation "should become meaningful across the marketplace." **REC** **It largely should not, and designing as if it does will produce unsafe recommendations.**

Reputation has two components and they behave completely differently:

|                                                                                             | Transfers across categories? | Why                                                                                            |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Integrity &amp; reliability</b> — shows up, on time, communicates, honest, doesn't steal | <b>Yes</b>                   | These are properties of a person                                                               |
| <b>Competence</b> — can actually do the job well                                            | <b>No</b>                    | Mary being an excellent cleaner is zero evidence she can inspect an apartment or wire a socket |

**REC** **Build one portable Reliability score and separate, non-portable, per-category Competence scores.** Never let a high cross-platform score imply competence in a category the provider has never worked in. This is the difference between a trust system and a liability. Detail in `06-trust-architecture.md`.



## 9. Where to go next

| Document                      | Covers brief sections                                                       |
|-------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 01-what-changed.md            | 2, 50 — old vs new, and what survives                                       |
| 02-competitive-landscape.md   | 41, 42 — the graveyard, global models, what transfers                       |
| 03-market-and-personas.md     | 6, 7, 8 — opportunity, customer and provider personas                       |
| 04-transaction-primitive.md   | 10-14, 23, 38, 51 — taxonomy, the primitive, booking models, state machines |
| 05-storefronts-and-ux.md      | 15, 32, 45, 46, 47, 52 — storefronts, UX, promises, homepage                |
| 06-trust-architecture.md      | 5, 16-20, 25, 26, 28, 54 — trust, verification, reputation, safety, fraud   |
| 07-payments.md                | 21, 22, 23, 24 — payment architecture, escrow, M-Pesa, disputes             |
| 08-liquidity-and-growth.md    | 27-35 — cold start, density, disintermediation, acquisition, loops          |
| 09-verticals.md               | 36-40, 60 — each vertical assessed, launch recommendation                   |
| 10-business-model.md          | 9, 30, 43, 44, 57 — economics, pricing, unit economics, financial model     |
| 11-roadmap.md                 | 45, 46, 47, 48, 61, 62, 63 — MVP, V2, V3, 90-day, 12-month, 3-year          |
| 12-technical-architecture.md  | 36, 37, 48, 49, 50, 53 — stack, schema, entities, ops console               |
| 13-metrics.md                 | 55, 56 — metrics and marketplace KPIs                                       |
| 14-risks-and-regulatory.md    | 64, 65, 66 — risks, failure modes, compliance                               |
| 15-brand-and-investor-case.md | 44, 67, 68, 69 — brand, narrative, defensibility, final recommendation      |
| archive-creator-marketplace/  | The original 109-page blueprint, now the Vertical 2 playbook                |

# What Changed, and What Survives

## The two companies, side by side

|               | OLD — Creator Collaboration Marketplace               | NEW — Trusted Services Marketplace                           |
|---------------|-------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| Demand side   | Brands with marketing budgets                         | People and businesses with things that need doing            |
| Supply side   | Creators                                              | Anyone who can be verified and held accountable              |
| Unit of value | A campaign                                            | <b>A completed, protected transaction</b>                    |
| Trigger       | "We need content"                                     | "I need someone I can trust"                                 |
| Ceiling       | <b>FACT</b> ~\$2-3M measured Kenyan influencer market | Bounded by category selection, not by a single ad budget     |
| Moat claim    | The settlement ledger                                 | Operational trust capability, per vertical, compounding      |
| Failure mode  | Market too small                                      | <b>Spreading too thin before reaching liquidity anywhere</b> |

**REC** The most important line in that table is the last one. You have traded a *size* risk for an *execution* risk. That is a reasonable trade — size risk is fatal and unfixable, execution risk is manageable — but only if you actually manage it. The way you manage it is by refusing to launch horizontally.

## What survives from the original blueprint

More than you might expect. Roughly 70% of the previous work transfers intact, because it was about *transacting safely between strangers*, not about creators.

| Concept                                           | Status                                         | Change required                                           |
|---------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| Escrow funded before work begins                  | ✓ Survives                                     | None                                                      |
| <b>5-day auto-approve protecting the provider</b> | ✓ Survives — now more important                | None                                                      |
| Two-sided reputation                              | ✓ Survives                                     | Split into portable Reliability + per-category Competence |
| Storefronts with published prices                 | ✓ Survives, generalised                        | @creator → @provider                                      |
| <b>Deal Desk</b> (bring your own customer)        | ✓ Survives — now the primary cold-start weapon | Generalised to all providers                              |

| Concept                                         | Status                  | Change required                                                    |
|-------------------------------------------------|-------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Append-only event log + double-entry ledger     | ✓ Survives              | None — becomes more valuable                                       |
| Descending repeat fees                          | ✓ Survives              | Rebalanced; see 08                                                 |
| Structured briefs preventing disputes           | ✓ Survives              | Becomes structured <i>job specs</i>                                |
| Watermark gate (asset released on settlement)   | ✓ Survives, narrowed    | Applies to digital deliverables only                               |
| Aggregator-first payment architecture           | ✓ Survives              | None                                                               |
| Provider keeps 100%, buyer pays the fee         | ⚠ Revised               | Does not survive contact with low-AOV or quote-based work — see 10 |
| Campaign-in-a-Box                               | ✓ Survives, generalised | Becomes productised outcomes across verticals                      |
| AI matching deferred until data exists          | ✓ Survives              | None                                                               |
| "The ledger is the moat"                        | ⚠ Downgraded            | Reframed as consequence, not strategy — see 00 §7                  |
| Kenya influencer market sizing                  | 📦 Archived              | Now scopes one vertical, not the company                           |
| Creator tiers, audience authenticity, Spark Ads | 📦 Archived to vertical  | Still correct <i>for creators</i> ; irrelevant to fundis           |

**REC** **The single biggest conceptual change:** the previous blueprint's core primitive was a `Collaboration` with ten campaign-type presets. The new primitive is a `ServiceTransaction` with pricing-model and fulfilment-mode variants. A creator campaign becomes one shape of it. Detail in 04-transaction-primitive.md.

## What is genuinely new

- Physical-world risk.** The old marketplace's worst outcome was a bad video. The new one dispatches people to addresses, sometimes on behalf of someone who is not there. Safety and agency risk become first-class product concerns, not a policy page. ( 06 )
- Non-digital supply.** Creators are digitally native by definition. Fundis and inspectors are not uniformly so. Onboarding, briefing and proof capture must work for someone with a mid-range Android phone on patchy data.
- Quote-based and variable-scope work.** A UGC video has a price. "Paint my apartment" does not until someone looks at it. The transaction primitive must support quoting, revision of scope, and — critically — **materials money**, which is the largest single trust failure in Kenyan fundi work.
- Reputation no longer transfers cleanly.** ( 00 §8 )
- Regulatory surface widens** — domestic work classification, property representation, regulated professions. ( 14 )

## The strategic sentence

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**Old:** Brands need creators. **New:** People need things done, and cannot tell who to trust. **Ours:** We are the verified stranger — starting with the customers for whom trust is worth the most, not the ones for whom it is cheapest to serve.

That last clause is the whole revision. Your brief instinctively reached for the highest-*frequency* categories. The economics in 00 §3 say to reach for the highest-*trust-deficit* categories instead, because that is where the fee is defensible and the leakage is lowest.

# Competitive Landscape

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## A. The Kenyan graveyard — read this first

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### Lynk (2015-2022)

**FACT** Founded in Nairobi by Adam Grunewald and Johannes Degn. Connected households and businesses with **verified domestic workers, fundis, artisans and blue-collar professionals**, across dozens of categories including furniture, beauty, installation, repair and maintenance. Acquired by Eden Life (Nigeria) in 2022, facilitated by Enza Capital.

**FACT** **What they learned, in their own framing:** - The defining early question was **lead-gen vs full-service** — connect and step away, or own the whole delivery. - They **pivoted operating models multiple times** searching for one that worked at scale in Nairobi. - They shifted **from an auction marketplace to a standardised service model**. - **Vetting and training costs were high**. Partnerships with vocational training providers never took off, forcing them to build **Lynk Academy** in-house for recruiting, vetting and training. - **Class friction was a real product problem:** customers, often from significantly higher social classes than the providers, would unfairly mistrust tradespeople — assuming they were cheating or delivering poor work — because of prior bad experience or communication difficulties.

**REC** **Three lessons to internalise:** 1. **The auction/bidding model failed and they moved to standardisation.** Your brief's section 8 "Post a Task → providers quote" is the model Lynk abandoned. Use it narrowly, not as the default. 2. **Supply vetting is the cost centre that breaks the model.** Any plan that assumes cheap provider onboarding is wrong. Budget for it or pick a vertical where supply is easier to verify. 3. **ASSUMPTION** The class-mistrust finding suggests the platform must arbitrate *perception*, not just quality — structured scope, photographic evidence, fixed pricing and a neutral dispute process exist partly to protect providers from unfair customer judgement. That is a product requirement, not a nicety.

### SweepSouth in Kenya (2019-2022)

**FACT** Founded 2014 by Aisha Pandor and Alen Ribic; **\$15M+ raised**; ~40,000 bookings/month across its markets. Entered **Kenya 2019**, Nigeria June 2022, **closed both on 25 November 2022**, citing economic conditions. Commentary described the expansions as half-hearted, with shoddy operational setup, slow technology and unstable websites. Still operating in South Africa, and in Egypt via its FilKhedma acquisition.

**REC** **The lesson is not "cleaning doesn't work" — it works in South Africa.** The lesson is that **home-services marketplaces do not travel**, because the asset is local operational capability, not software. This cuts both ways for you: it is why an outside player is unlikely to crush you in Nairobi, and why your own expansion to Kampala will be a fresh build rather than a rollout.

### Who is operating in Kenya now

**FACT** My-Fundi (verified plumbers, electricians, carpenters), Balozy (fundi marketplace spanning plumbers, DJs, tutors; multi-city — Nairobi, Kisumu, Nyeri, Eldoret, Bomet, Siaya), Kalinoi (cleaning, caregiving, gardening, events, tech repairs **and social-content creators**), Juakali Hub, Cleaner-Kenya, plus classifieds like PigiaMe.

**REC** Note Kalinoi carefully — it already spans home services *and* creators. The horizontal concept in your brief is not unclaimed. **ASSUMPTION** I could not verify any of these players' scale, funding or transaction volume; their public presence suggests early stage. **Sign up for each and transact before finalising strategy** — desk research cannot tell you whether these are real marketplaces or directories with a booking form.

## B. Africa beyond Kenya

| Company           | Market         | <b>FACT</b> Status                                                                                                                                    |
|-------------------|----------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Kandua</b>     | South Africa   | Raised <b>\$13M</b> ; <b>acquired by Santam (insurer), May 2024</b> ; had built embedded financial services; launching an AI "home companion" in 2026 |
| <b>SweepSouth</b> | SA, Egypt      | \$15M+; exited Kenya and Nigeria 2022; acquired FilKhedma (Egypt)                                                                                     |
| <b>Eden Life</b>  | Nigeria, Kenya | Raised <b>\$2.26M</b> ; subscription home services; acquired Lynk 2022; <b>has since rebranded toward an e-commerce marketplace</b>                   |

**REC** Two signals worth more than the rest of this document:

1. **Kandua's exit was to an insurer, not a tech acquirer.** The value that accumulated was a verified network of vetted tradespeople and a claim on the home-services relationship — an *insurance distribution and risk* asset. This is the honest version of the "ledger as moat" thesis, and it is a plausible outcome, not a plan.
2. **Eden Life bought a services marketplace and then drifted to e-commerce.** **ASSUMPTION** That is the behaviour of a company that found selling *goods* easier to scale than selling *labour*. Treat it as a caution.

## C. Global models — what actually worked

| Platform             | Model                                                                                                   | <b>FACT</b> Outcome / economics                                                                                              | Transferable lesson                                                                                                                                      |
|----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Urban Company</b> | <b>Managed vertical marketplace</b> — controls onboarding, training, equipment, pricing, scheduling, QC | 50,000+ professionals; provider incomes reportedly 3–5×; India home-services TAM ₹4,990–5,070B (2024) → ₹8,220–8,350B (2029) | <b>The only unambiguous success, and it is managed and vertical.</b> "Pure marketplace aggregation didn't work — supply quality couldn't be controlled." |
| <b>TaskRabbit</b>    | Horizontal task marketplace                                                                             | Acquired by IKEA 2017; LTV:CAC ~ <b>4:1</b>                                                                                  | Retention is achievable, but it needed a strategic owner                                                                                                 |
| <b>Handy</b>         | Home services                                                                                           | Acquired by ANGI; <b>struggled to exceed 2:1 LTV:CAC</b>                                                                     | Churn kills home services                                                                                                                                |
| <b>Thumbtack</b>     | <b>Lead generation</b> — pros pay per lead                                                              | <b>\$400M revenue FY2024 (+27%); \$8–150+ per lead, shared with 4–5 pros</b>                                                 | Big revenue, but revenue decouples from completed jobs                                                                                                   |
| <b>Airtasker</b>     | Transactional marketplace                                                                               | <b>AUD 52.7M revenue FY2025</b> ; ~10–20% service fee; 92% transaction-based                                                 | A real but modest business after a decade                                                                                                                |

| Platform                        | Model | <b>FACT</b> Outcome / economics   | Transferable lesson           |
|---------------------------------|-------|-----------------------------------|-------------------------------|
| Lead-gen marketplaces generally | —     | <b>Repeat rates as low as 15%</b> | Lead-gen does not build habit |

## The three structural findings

**1. Managed beats marketplace in physical services; marketplace beats managed in digital services.** Physical work has variable quality that only training and control can fix. Digital work has portfolios you can inspect before buying. **REC** **This is why your creator vertical can stay light-touch while your fundi vertical cannot** — and why treating them as one product is a mistake.

**2. Lead-gen monetises well and serves customers badly.** **FACT** Thumbtack does \$400M on a model where a pro pays \$8-150 for a lead shared with 4-5 competitors, whether or not it converts. **REC** **Do not build this in Kenya.** It extracts from providers who cannot afford it, produces no completion data, and generates the reputation-free experience your entire thesis is against. It is also the fastest way to be resented by supply.

**3. The transactional model is the right one and it is slower.** Airtasker's ~10-20% on completed work is the honest version. It grows more slowly than lead-gen and it compounds, because every transaction produces trust data.

## D. What none of them solved, and you might

**REC** Three gaps are genuinely open, and two of them are specific to your market:

- 1. The remote principal.** No platform above serves *"I am not there; act for me and tell me the truth."* TaskRabbit assumes you are home. Urban Company assumes you are home. **FACT** Kenya has US\$5B/year in remittances and documented, worsening fraud against distant buyers. This is the wedge in 00 \$5.
- 2. Materials money.** Kenyan fundi work routinely involves the customer advancing cash for materials, which is where trust most often breaks. No platform I found treats the materials advance as a distinct escrowed, receipted, evidenced stage. **REC** **This is a concrete, buildable differentiator for the fundi vertical.**
- 3. Provider-side dignity and professionalisation.** **FACT** Urban Company's stated moat is value creation on the supply side — training providers and multiplying their incomes. Lynk found the same and had to build an academy. **REC** **In a market where supply is abundant and unverified, the platform that makes providers *more employable* owns supply.**

# Market Opportunity and Personas

## The market, sized honestly

**REC** **Refuse to produce a TAM number you cannot defend.** There is no credible published figure for "Kenyan trusted-services spend," and manufacturing one from population × arbitrary spend is the kind of slide that ends diligence. What follows is what is actually knowable.

**FACT** **Anchors that are real:**

| Anchor                                | Value                                                                                        | Source                            |
|---------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|
| Kenya diaspora remittances            | <b>US\$5.04B (2025); US\$4.96B 12mo to Jun 2026; CBK projects US\$5.24B (2026)</b>           | CBK via Business Daily / The Star |
| Kenya internet users                  | 23.4M (40.5%) end-2025                                                                       | DataReportal                      |
| Domestic workers in Kenya             | <b>&gt;2 million</b> , mostly informal, verbal agreements                                    | Kudheisha / press                 |
| Gazetted domestic-worker minimum wage | <b>KSh 18,047/month</b> (Nairobi, Mombasa, Kisumu, Nakuru, Eldoret); KSh 9,268 smaller towns | Daily Nation                      |
| Kenya digital advertising             | US\$95.5M (2024) → US\$119.4M (2028)                                                         | Statista                          |
| Kenya influencer advertising          | US\$2.1M (2024) → US\$3.0M (2028)                                                            | Statista                          |

**ASSUMPTION** **What these anchors imply.** The remittance figure is *not* a services TAM — it is overwhelmingly household support, education and property. But it establishes two things that are strategically decisive: a large population of Kenyans who **routinely move significant money into Kenya from a distance**, and an existing habit of **paying for outcomes they cannot personally verify**. The share of that flow that would attach to a paid verification or representation service is unknown and must be measured, not modelled.

**REC** **The one number to go and get in the first 30 days:** *what will a diaspora Kenyan pay, today, for a verified stranger to inspect a property and produce an evidenced report before they send a deposit?* Twenty conversations answers it. No amount of desk research will.

## Customer personas

### P1 — The Remote Principal (*launch customer*)

**Wanjiru, 38, nurse in Manchester.** Sends money home monthly. Is buying a plot in Kitengela from a developer she found on Facebook. Has been shown photos she cannot verify. Her cousin "checked it out" and was vague. She has read about diaspora land scams and is frightened but proceeding anyway because she has been saving for six years.



- **Job to be done:** *"Tell me the truth about something I cannot see, before I send money I cannot get back."*
- **Willingness to pay:** **ASSUMPTION High** — she is contemplating a six-figure-shilling transfer; a KSh 6,000 inspection is rounding error insurance. This is the core assumption of the whole strategy and must be tested first.
- **Frequency:** Low as a buyer (2-4/year), **higher once she owns property** (tenant vetting, rent oversight, quarterly checks, repairs supervision).
- **Why she cannot disintermediate:** she has no trusted local network — that is the entire reason she is here. Her existing network is the failure mode.
- **Where she is:** UK, US, Canada, Gulf states. Concentrated in diaspora WhatsApp groups, SACCOs, church networks, investment chamas.

## P2 — The Upcountry Principal

**Kiprop, 51, farmer in Eldoret.** Daughter is at university in Nairobi. Owns a rental flat in Kasarani managed by a caretaker he does not fully trust. Travels to Nairobi twice a year and dreads it.

Same job, domestic version, lower price point, **ASSUMPTION** larger population, harder to reach. **REC**  
**Serve second — the diaspora segment has higher willingness to pay and better channel concentration.**

## P3 — The Nairobi Householder (*the obvious customer — deprioritised*)

**Mercy, 34, Kilimani.** Needs her sink fixed and her apartment painted. Currently asks the estate WhatsApp group.

- **Job:** *"Find me a fundi who won't overcharge me, botch it, or vanish with the materials money."*
- **REC Real customer, genuine pain, but she is Vertical 3.** Her repair jobs clear the KSh 5,000 line; her cleaning and errands do not. Serve her for fundi work once trust operations are proven — not at launch.

## P4 — The SME Owner (*Vertical 2 — the existing blueprint*)

**Otieno, 41, restaurant in Westlands.** Needs content, photography, occasional creators. Fully specified in [archive-creator-marketplace/](#). High AOV, digital delivery, recurring need.

## P5 — The Property-Owning Landlord

**Njeri, 46, owns three rental units across Nairobi.** Needs tenant vetting, viewings conducted, repairs supervised, deposits verified. **REC The bridge persona.** She is local, recurring, high-value, and buys exactly the same service catalogue as P1. Onboarding her makes the supply pool busy between diaspora jobs.

## Provider personas

### S1 — The Verifier / Local Agent (*launch supply*)

**Brian, 29, Nairobi.** Diploma-educated, underemployed, smartphone with decent camera, moves around the city, writes clearly, wants professional work.

- **Why this supply is easier than funds:** the core competencies are **integrity, observation, documentation and communication** — assessable in an interview and a paid trial, not requiring a trade qualification or an academy. **FACT** Lynk's cost centre was vetting and training tradespeople; this pool sidesteps most of it.
- **Why it is harder:** you are placing him in an **agency relationship near money**. A dishonest inspector who takes KSh 20,000 from a seller to write a clean report destroys a KSh 500,000 customer outcome. **This is the central supply risk and it is addressed in 06.**
- **REC** **Small, deeply vetted, well-paid, heavily monitored pool. Do not scale this supply quickly.** Quality here is the product.

### S2 — The Fundi

**Kamau, 36, plumber, Kasarani.** Skilled, no formal certification, gets work by referral and WhatsApp, is periodically stiffed by customers, occasionally accused of overcharging.

**FACT** **Note the symmetry Lynk discovered:** he is also a victim of the trust deficit — customers of higher social class assume he is cheating. **REC** **The provider-protection story (agreed scope, escrowed funds so he knows he'll be paid, evidenced completion, a neutral dispute process) is as strong a recruitment message as customer acquisition.**

### S3 — The Creator / Digital Professional

Fully specified in the archive. Digitally native, portfolio-assessable, remote-deliverable.

### S4 — The Domestic Worker

**REC** **Explicitly out of scope.** **FACT** Gazetted minimum wage of KSh 18,047/month; >2M workers, largely informal. **LEGAL — COUNSEL REQUIRED** placement and platform-mediated domestic work carry employment-classification and labour-law exposure materially different from booking a tradesperson. This is a deliberate exclusion, not an oversight.

## The demand-side insight that should shape the product

**REC** Across P1, P2, P3 and P5, the customer is never really buying a service. They are buying **the removal of a specific fear**:

| Persona          | The fear                                             |
|------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| Remote principal | "I will send money and there will be nothing there." |

| Persona             | The fear                                                            |
|---------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Upcountry principal | "I am being quietly robbed and cannot check."                       |
| Householder         | "He will overcharge me, or take the materials money and disappear." |
| Landlord            | "My caretaker is lying to me."                                      |
| SME owner           | "I will pay and get nothing usable."                                |

**Sell against the fear, not the category.** *"Know before you pay"* is a stronger proposition than *"book a property inspector."* This is also why the homepage in 05 leads with a question, not a taxonomy.

# The Service Transaction Primitive

## The abstraction

Your brief is right that the core object must not be `creator_campaign`. It is:

```
SERVICE_TRANSACTION
├── parties          customer ↔ provider          (either may be a business)
├── need            what outcome is being bought
├── scope           ScopeItem[]                  ← what "done" means, explicitly
├── pricing_model    fixed | quote | hourly | recurring | application
├── fulfilment       remote_digital | on_site | at_provider | representation
├── schedule         when, where, how long, recurrence rule
├── money            Escrow + Milestone[] + Disbursement[]
├── evidence         Evidence[]                  ← how completion is proven
└── outcome          Review[] + ReputationEvent[] + DisputeRecord?
```

Every job in every vertical is this object. A UGC video, a plumbing repair, a property inspection and a weekly office clean differ in **five enum values and the shape of evidence** — not in structure.

**REC** The two fields that do the most work are `scope` and `evidence`, and they are the two most commonly under-designed. Nearly every dispute in a services marketplace reduces to *"we disagreed about what was included"* or *"we disagreed about whether it was done."* Structure both and you prevent most disputes rather than adjudicating them.

## Pricing models — one primitive, five shapes

| Model              | Example                                  | Escrow behaviour                       | <b>REC</b> Use for                    |
|--------------------|------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| <b>Fixed</b>       | "Property inspection — KSh 6,000"        | Full amount at booking                 | <b>Default. Push everything here.</b> |
| <b>Quote</b>       | "Paint my 3-bed apartment"               | Escrow on quote acceptance             | Variable-scope trade work             |
| <b>Hourly</b>      | "Assistant — KSh 800/hr"                 | Escrow an estimated cap; refund unused | Rare; needs verified time             |
| <b>Recurring</b>   | "Quarterly property check"               | Escrow per occurrence, not upfront     | Retention engine ( 08 )               |
| <b>Application</b> | "I need a TikTok creator for this brief" | Escrow on selection                    | Creator vertical; multi-provider jobs |

**REC** Bias the catalogue hard toward Fixed. **FACT** Lynk abandoned its auction marketplace for a standardised service model — that is the most expensive lesson available to you, already paid for. Quoting is slow, produces price anxiety, invites off-platform negotiation, and gives you no comparable price data. Every service you can convert from "get quotes" to "KSh X, this is what's included" increases conversion and reduces leakage.

**Fixed-price productisation is possible far further up the value chain than people assume:**

| Instead of                 | Sell                                                                                                                 |
|----------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| "Get quotes for a plumber" | <b>"Fix a leaking tap or pipe — KSh 3,500. Diagnosis + repair + parts up to KSh 800."</b>                            |
| "Get quotes for painting"  | <b>"Paint a 1-bedroom — KSh 22,000, 2 days, paint included, 30-day workmanship guarantee."</b>                       |
| "House hunting"            | <b>"Property inspection report — KSh 6,000. Photos, video walkthrough, 12-point checklist, verified within 48h."</b> |

## Fulfilment modes — this is what actually varies

| Mode                     | Who is present                            | Evidence of completion             | Risk profile                    |
|--------------------------|-------------------------------------------|------------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| remote_digital           | Nobody                                    | The file itself                    | Low — IP and quality            |
| on_site_customer_present | Both                                      | Customer confirms                  | Medium — safety, scope          |
| on_site_customer_absent  | Provider only                             | <b>Photo/video/checklist</b>       | High — property, theft, honesty |
| at_provider              | Customer travels                          | Customer confirms                  | Low                             |
| representation           | <b>Provider acts for absent principal</b> | <b>Structured evidenced report</b> | <b>Highest — agency risk</b>    |

**REC** **representation** is a distinct mode and not a variant of **on\_site**. In every other mode the provider performs a task. In representation the provider **exercises judgement on someone else's behalf, at a distance, usually with money at stake**. It requires: a structured report format (not free text), tamper-evident evidence capture, an explicit conflict-of-interest declaration, and — for high-value matters — dual coverage. See 06.

## The three buying experiences (Brief §8, §9)

### Model 1 — Book a service (*the default; ~70% of volume*)

Customer knows what they need → browses a productised catalogue or a storefront → sees fixed price and availability → books and pays → done. **REC** **Optimise for this relentlessly**. It is the only flow with no waiting, no negotiation and no drop-off between intent and payment.

### Model 2 — Post a task (*the fallback; ~25%*)

Customer describes a need → matched providers quote → customer selects on price, rating, history and availability.

**REC** **Constrain this hard, because it is the model Lynk abandoned:** - **Cap quotes at 5**. More is noise and wastes provider effort. - **Show a platform price guide** from real completed transactions, so the customer is not anchoring blind. - **Quotes expire in 24 hours**. - **Providers have a weekly quote quota** that grows with reputation — this is the anti-spam mechanism and it also prevents the

Thumbtack failure where pros pay to shout. - **Never charge providers to quote.** **FACT** Thumbtack charges \$8-150 per lead shared with 4-5 pros; that model extracts from supply and decouples revenue from completed work. It would be resented and it kills your data. - **Every completed Model 2 job is a product backlog item:** if a task shape recurs, productise it into Model 1 with a fixed price.

### Model 3 — "Just ask" (V2/V3, not MVP)

Free-text need → structured request. **REC** **At MVP this is a human, not a model.** Ops reads the request and builds the job. That is faster to ship, more accurate, and — as with the previous blueprint — the manual process is the specification for the eventual automation. Do not build the LLM layer before you have several hundred real requests to train the taxonomy on.

## Scope: the anti-dispute structure

```
ScopeItem:
  description: "Photograph and video every room, including ceilings and under sinks"
  included: true
  quantity: 1
  acceptance_criterion: "Minimum 20 photos + 1 continuous video walkthrough"

exclusions:                # explicit, mandatory, non-empty
- "Structural or legal opinion on title"
- "Negotiation with the landlord or agent"

materials:                  # THE Kenyan fundi trust failure — model it explicitly
  who_supplies: provider | customer | platform_advance
  budget_kes: 800
  receipts_required: true
  unused_returned: true
```

**REC** **The materials block is one of the highest-value things in this document.** Advancing cash for materials — and its disappearance, inflation, or substitution with inferior goods — is the single most common trust breakdown in Kenyan trade work, and no competitor I found models it. Treat the materials advance as a **separately escrowed, receipted, photographed milestone**. It protects the customer from theft and the honest fundi from suspicion, which — per Lynk's class-mistrust finding — matters just as much.

## Evidence: how "done" is proven

```
Evidence:
  type: photo | video | document | checklist | geo_checkin | qr_scan
        | customer_confirmation | file_delivery
  captured_at, captured_by
  geo: {lat, lng, accuracy}    # captured in-app, not uploaded from gallery
  device_attested: bool
  hash                        # tamper-evidence
```

**REC** **Three rules:** 1. **Evidence requirements are declared in the job spec before work starts**, so both sides know what completion looks like. 2. **In-app capture with geotag for on-site and representation modes.** A gallery upload proves nothing; a photo taken in-app at the property at 14:22

proves a great deal. 3. **Evidence is the release trigger.** No evidence, no release — and correspondingly, complete evidence plus customer silence triggers **auto-release at 5 days** exactly as in the original blueprint. That protection is more important here, not less: a fundi who has bought materials and done a day's labour cannot be left unpaid because a customer stopped replying.

## State machines (Brief §38, §51)

**REC** **One core lifecycle, with optional stages switched on per fulfilment mode.** Your brief correctly warns against one giant unmaintainable machine; the answer is a small spine plus mode-specific extensions, not five parallel machines.

— THE SPINE (every transaction) —

DRAFT → REQUESTED → [QUOTED → QUOTE\_ACCEPTED] → FUNDED → SCHEDULED  
→ IN\_PROGRESS → EVIDENCE\_SUBMITTED → CUSTOMER\_REVIEW  
→ APPROVED → RELEASED → SETTLED → REVIEWED → CLOSED

Terminal at any point: CANCELLED\_BY\_CUSTOMER · CANCELLED\_BY\_PROVIDER  
EXPIRED · DISPUTED · REFUNDED

Mode-specific stages inserted into the spine:

| Mode                     | Extra stages                                                      |
|--------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| on_site / representation | PROVIDER_EN_ROUTE → CHECKED_IN → ON_SITE_COMPLETE                 |
| Quote-based              | SITE_VISIT_SCHEDULED → SCOPE_AGREED                               |
| With materials           | MATERIALS_ADVANCED → MATERIALS_RECEIVED                           |
| Recurring                | Parent SERIES spawns child transactions; each runs the full spine |
| Application (creator)    | APPLIED → SHORTLISTED → SELECTED                                  |

**The timers, which are the real product:**

| Timer                               | Duration                 | On expiry                           | Protects        |
|-------------------------------------|--------------------------|-------------------------------------|-----------------|
| Quote validity                      | 24h                      | Expire                              | Customer        |
| Acceptance → funding                | 24h                      | Cancel + customer penalty           | <b>Provider</b> |
| Scheduled → check-in                | 30 min grace             | Late flag; customer may cancel free | Customer        |
| <b>Evidence → customer decision</b> | <b>5 days</b>            | <b>AUTO-APPROVE + RELEASE</b>       | <b>Provider</b> |
| Approval → payout                   | <b>&lt;60 min target</b> | Escalation alert                    | <b>Provider</b> |
| Escrow maximum life                 | 60 days                  | Force-resolve                       | Compliance      |
| Review window                       | 14 days                  | Double-blind reveal                 | Both            |

**REC** Every transition emits an immutable event. Reputation, analytics, dispute evidence and eventual model training are all *derived* from that log and never stored as mutable fields — unchanged from the original blueprint, and now serving five verticals instead of one.

# Storefronts and UX

## The homepage (Brief §45)

**REC** One question, examples that teach the taxonomy, and proof. Nothing else above the fold.

What do you need done?

Describe it, or pick below... →

"Inspect an apartment before I pay the deposit"

"Check on my rental property in Kasarani"

"Fix a leaking pipe"

"Create 3 TikTok videos for my restaurant"

---

Every job is paid into escrow. Nobody gets paid until you confirm the work is done.

✓ ID-verified providers    ✓ M-Pesa    ✓ Full refund if the job isn't done

**REC Three deliberate choices.** The example prompts are *the* taxonomy-teaching mechanism — a customer who cannot find their need in a category grid will leave, but one who reads four examples understands the platform's range in three seconds. The trust promise sits above the fold because it is the product. And there is **no category grid on the homepage** — categories are for people who already know what they want, and they are one tap away.

**REC Do not put "creators" on the homepage.** Vertical 2 is reached through business-oriented entry points and direct storefront links, not the consumer front door. Mixing "inspect my property" with "hire a TikTok creator" in one grid makes the platform look unserious to both audiences.

## Service storefronts (Brief §15, §32)

Generalised directly from the creator storefront, which was the strongest idea in the original blueprint.



platform.co.ke/@brian-m

|                                                        |           |        |        |
|--------------------------------------------------------|-----------|--------|--------|
| [photo] Brian Mwangi ✓ ID verified                     |           |        |        |
| Property Verification · Nairobi                        |           |        |        |
| ★ 4.9 (63 jobs) · 98% on-time · Replies ~40m           |           |        |        |
| Reliability 94 · Verification competence: 63           |           |        |        |
| SERVICES                                               |           |        |        |
| Property inspection + report                           | KSh 6,000 | 48h    | [Book] |
| Property viewing on your behalf                        | KSh 4,500 | 72h    | [Book] |
| Quarterly property check                               | KSh 5,500 | /visit | [Book] |
| Document collection & courier                          | KSh 3,500 | 48h    | [Book] |
| SAMPLE REPORT [view a redacted real report ▶]          |           |        |        |
| COVERAGE Kilimani · Kileleshwa · Lavington · Westlands |           |        |        |
| RECENT "Saved me from a fake agent." – J.K., London    |           |        |        |

#### REC Four things this must do that the creator version did not:

1. **Show the sample deliverable.** For a creator the portfolio *is* the proof. For a verifier, the equivalent is a **redacted real inspection report**. A customer who reads one understands the value instantly and stops price-shopping. This is the single highest-converting element on the page.
2. **Show coverage area, not just city.** Travel time is the constraint that determines whether a booking is realistic.
3. **Separate Reliability from Competence.** Displaying one blended score would imply Brian can rewire a socket. He cannot. ( 06 )
4. **Never show "0 jobs" nakedly for a new provider.** Show what has been verified instead: *"ID verified · Trained & assessed · Platform-guaranteed."* Cold start is a design problem, not just an algorithm problem.

**REC The storefront remains a distribution channel, exactly as before.** A provider who shares platform.co.ke/@brian-m in a WhatsApp status, a diaspora Facebook group or a Google Business Profile is saying *"book me safely"* — and acquiring your demand for you. **REC This is the cheapest customer acquisition available and it should be instrumented from day one:** every storefront gets a share sheet, a QR code, and an attribution parameter.

## The two promises (Brief \$46, \$47)

**REC Use these as the literal information architecture, not just marketing.** Each stage is a screen and a state.

### Customer

|             |                                         |                              |
|-------------|-----------------------------------------|------------------------------|
| FIND        | Describe it, or pick a service.         | → matched, priced, available |
| TRUST       | See who they are and what they've done. | → verification + history     |
| PAY         | Money held safely until you confirm.    | → escrow, visible            |
| GET IT DONE | Track it. See the evidence.             | → live status + proof        |
| REPEAT      | Book them again in one tap.             | → rebook                     |

## Provider

|                |                                                       |
|----------------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| GET CUSTOMERS  | A profile people can book directly                    |
| GET PAID       | Escrowed before you start. M-Pesa within the hour.    |
| BUILD STANDING | Every completed job is a verified record              |
| GROW           | Repeat customers, higher-value work, better placement |

**REC** "Escrowed before you start" is the recruitment line. **FACT** Lynk found customers unfairly mistrusted tradespeople; the mirror of that is that tradespeople are routinely not paid. A provider who can see the money is already held has a reason to prefer you that no competitor in Kenya is currently offering him.

## Customer navigation

Home (what do you need?) · My jobs · Messages · Payments · Profile

**REC** "My jobs" is the retention surface, not "Explore." In a services marketplace the returning user is checking on work, not browsing. Put live job status first, completed jobs (with one-tap rebook) second, and discovery third.

## Provider navigation

Today · Opportunities · Jobs · Earnings · Profile

**REC** "Today" first. A provider opens the app to answer one question: *what do I have on right now, and where do I need to be?* **REC** And "Earnings" must show pending, in-escrow and paid separately — visible escrowed money is the single most reassuring thing in the provider experience.

**REC** Design the provider app for a mid-range Android on patchy data. Offline-tolerant evidence capture with background upload is not a nicety: a provider standing in a basement with no signal must be able to complete a job and have it sync later. **FACT** SweepSouth's Kenya failure was attributed partly to slow, unstable technology in new markets — provider-side reliability is where that shows first.

## Productised outcomes (Brief \$17, generalised)

The Campaign-in-a-Box idea, generalised. **REC** Sell outcomes with names, prices and inclusions — never "browse providers."

| Vertical     | Product                    | Price           | Inclusions                                                                          |
|--------------|----------------------------|-----------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Verification | Know Before You Pay        | KSh 6,000       | Inspection, 20+ geotagged photos, video walkthrough, 12-point checklist, 48h report |
| Verification | Viewed For You             | KSh 4,500       | Attend viewing, video call you in live, report                                      |
| Verification | Landlord's Quarterly Check | KSh 5,500/visit | Condition check, meter readings, tenant confirmation, photo set                     |

| Vertical | Product                   | Price      | Inclusions                                            |
|----------|---------------------------|------------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| Fundi    | Fix My Leak               | KSh 3,500  | Diagnosis, repair, parts to KSh 800, 30-day guarantee |
| Fundi    | Paint My 1-Bed            | KSh 22,000 | Prep, 2 coats, paint included, 2 days, guarantee      |
| Business | 3 TikToks for My Business | KSh 13,000 | 3 videos, 1 revision, 90-day ad rights                |

**ASSUMPTION** Every price above is a placeholder to be validated in week one. They are shaped to clear the KSh 5,000 line, which is their only defensible property today.

## The rebook mechanic (Brief §25)

**REC** The second transaction must be the easiest thing in the product. After completion:

✓ Job complete. KSh 6,000 released to Brian.  
 [Book Brian again]    [Book this service again]    [Set up quarterly]

**REC** "Set up quarterly" is the highest-value button in the application. It converts a one-off into a recurring series, which is the difference between a transaction business and a retention business ( 08 ). Offer it at the exact moment of maximum satisfaction — immediately after a job the customer is happy with — and never by email a week later.

# Trust, Safety and Fraud

## The correction that governs this whole document

**REC** Reputation splits in two, and conflating them is how a trust platform becomes a liability.

|                                    | Portable across categories? | What it measures                                                          |
|------------------------------------|-----------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Reliability &amp; Integrity</b> | <b>Yes</b>                  | Shows up, on time, communicates, honest, doesn't steal, resolves problems |
| <b>Competence</b>                  | <b>No</b>                   | Can actually do <i>this specific job</i> well                             |

Mary being an outstanding cleaner is **zero evidence** she can inspect a property or wire a socket. A single blended "Trust Score 94" displayed across a horizontal marketplace actively misleads customers into unsafe hires, and it is the mechanism by which a platform's trust claim becomes a legal exposure.

| PORTABLE                                                                                                                         | NON-PORTABLE                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <div> Reliability 94<br/> – on-time 98%<br/> – completion 99%<br/> – response ~40m<br/> – disputes 1<br/> – ID verified ✓ </div> | <div> Verification  63 jobs<br/> Plumbing – 0 jobs<br/> Content – 0 jobs<br/> <br/> Competence is earned per category. It never transfers. </div> |

**REC** **Product rule: a provider may only appear in a category where they hold category-specific verification, regardless of how high their Reliability score is.** Reliability determines *ranking within* a category. It never grants *entry to* one.

## Verification: define every claim you make (Brief §28)

Your brief is right that "verified" and "background checked" must be operationally and legally defensible. **REC** **Publish a plain-language definition of every badge, and never use a word you cannot substantiate.**

| Badge                  | What it means <b>exactly</b>                                                                    | What it does <b>not</b> mean |
|------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------|
| <b>Phone verified</b>  | OTP to an M-Pesa-registered number                                                              | Nothing about identity       |
| <b>ID verified</b>     | National ID/passport captured, liveness selfie matched, <b>name matches M-Pesa registration</b> | No criminal history checked  |
| <b>Address on file</b> | Residential address collected and a utility bill or equivalent seen                             | Not independently visited    |

| Badge                    | What it means exactly                                                               | What it does not mean      |
|--------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------|
| <b>Referenced</b>        | Two prior customers or employers contacted by our team, notes on file               | Not a criminal check       |
| <b>Category assessed</b> | Passed our practical assessment for this category (test job, reviewed by ops)       | Not a state licence        |
| <b>Licensed</b>          | Holds a named third-party licence/certificate, <b>copy on file, issuer verified</b> | Only as good as the issuer |
| <b>Insured job</b>       | This booking is covered by our policy up to KSh X                                   | Not unlimited liability    |

**REC** **Do not claim "background checked."** **LEGAL — COUNSEL REQUIRED** Access to Kenyan criminal records for private screening is not something I could verify as reliably available to a platform, and the phrase creates an expectation you may not be able to meet. **REC** If you offer a Certificate of Good Conduct requirement for high-risk categories, describe it precisely as *"provider has supplied a Certificate of Good Conduct dated X"* — the specific, checkable claim — and confirm the lawful basis for collecting and retaining it under the Data Protection Act.

**REC** **Tier verification to risk, not to revenue:**

| Tier | Required for                                         | Requirements                                                                                                        |
|------|------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 0    | Browsing                                             | Phone OTP                                                                                                           |
| 1    | Any paid work                                        | ID verified + M-Pesa name match                                                                                     |
| 2    | On-site at customer premises                         | Tier 1 + address on file + 2 references + category assessment                                                       |
| 3    | <b>Representation / customer-absent / high-value</b> | <b>Tier 2 + Certificate of Good Conduct + in-person interview + paid trial job + conflict-of-interest agreement</b> |

## The agency problem — the hardest risk in this business

**REC** **This deserves its own treatment because it is the failure mode that would destroy the wedge, and no competitor design I found addresses it.**

When a provider inspects a property for a remote buyer, the provider can be **bribed by the seller or agent** to write a favourable report. The customer then sends a life-changing sum on the strength of your verification. **A single such incident, publicised in a diaspora Facebook group, ends the company.**

**REC** **Controls, layered — none sufficient alone:**

- 1. Structured reports, not opinions.** The deliverable is a **12-point checklist with mandatory geotagged photographic evidence per point**, not "looks fine to me." A dishonest inspector must fabricate evidence, not merely shade a judgement.
- 2. In-app capture only.** Photos and video taken in-app, geotagged and timestamped at the property, hashed on upload. Gallery uploads are rejected for Tier 3 work.
- 3. Conflict-of-interest declaration**, per job, contractual: the provider affirms no relationship with the seller, agent or landlord, and no payment received from them.

4. **The provider must never be introduced by, or introduced to, the counterparty by the platform's own routing.** Assign, don't let the seller choose.
5. **Random dual coverage.** **REC** For a sampled share of high-value jobs — and for every job above a value threshold — send a **second, independent inspector who does not know the first was sent**. Disagreement between reports is your strongest detection signal and the only real deterrent. Budget for it as a cost of goods, not overhead.
6. **Outcome follow-up.** Contact the customer 30–60 days later: did reality match the report? Feed the answer into the provider's Integrity score, weighted heavily.
7. **Never let the provider handle the customer's transaction money.** The platform's service is *information and representation*, not payment intermediation for the underlying property.  
**LEGAL — COUNSEL REQUIRED** — accepting or holding a customer's property deposit would materially change the regulatory analysis and should be avoided entirely.

**REC** **And be honest in the product about what the service is not.** An inspection report is evidence, not a legal guarantee of title. Overclaiming here is both a consumer-protection risk and a promise you cannot keep.

## The Trust Score (Brief §19, §20)

**REC** **Compute a composite for ranking. Never display a composite. Display components.**

|                             |      |                                         |  |
|-----------------------------|------|-----------------------------------------|--|
| Reliability (portable)      |      |                                         |  |
| on_time_rate                | 0.30 |                                         |  |
| completion_rate             | 0.30 | accepted → completed                    |  |
| response_time               | 0.15 |                                         |  |
| dispute_rate (inverted)     | 0.15 |                                         |  |
| cancellation (inverted)     | 0.10 |                                         |  |
| Competence (per category)   |      |                                         |  |
| customer_quality_rating     | 0.45 |                                         |  |
| rework_rate (inverted)      | 0.20 |                                         |  |
| first_time_right            | 0.20 |                                         |  |
| assessment_score            | 0.15 | decays as real jobs accumulate          |  |
| Integrity (portable, gated) |      |                                         |  |
| evidence_integrity          | 0.40 | in-app capture, dual-coverage agreement |  |
| outcome_follow_up           | 0.35 | did reality match the report            |  |
| policy_violations           | 0.25 | inverted                                |  |

**REC** **Five design rules, all carried over from the original blueprint because they were right:**

1. **Bayesian cold start.** New providers enter at the category median with wide uncertainty, never at zero.  $\text{score} = (\text{prior} \cdot k + \text{observed} \cdot n) / (k + n)$ ,  $k \approx 5$ . Otherwise no new provider is ever hired and supply calcifies — the explicit failure your brief warns about in §12.
2. **Rank by the lower confidence bound (Wilson), not the point estimate.** Three 5-star jobs must not outrank sixty 4.7-star jobs.
3. **180-day half-life.** Reputation must be losable and recoverable.
4. **Value-weight ratings.** A KSh 40,000 job counts more than a KSh 3,000 one.
5. **Ratings only from escrow-settled transactions.** This is the anti-gaming keystone: manipulating reputation costs real money through a KYC'd rail.

**REC Cold start, solved on the demand side rather than the algorithm side.** For a provider's first five jobs, show **"New — platform guaranteed"**: the platform underwrites the job, refunds the customer in full on any failure, and absorbs the loss. It converts an unranked provider into a safe choice and buys you the data the ranking needs. Budget it as customer acquisition cost.

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## Two-sided reputation (Brief §11, §26)

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**REC Customers must be rated too, and it matters more here than in the creator marketplace.**

Customer Trust  
✓ ID verified · 17 jobs · ★ 4.8 from providers  
Payment reliability 100% · Cancellation 4% · No no-shows

Components: identity verification, completed transactions, funding reliability, cancellation rate, no-show rate, dispute rate, provider ratings, scope-creep flags.

**REC Why this is not symmetrical politeness but a supply-acquisition tool.** **FACT** Lynk found customers of higher social class unfairly mistrusted tradespeople. A provider who can see that a customer has 17 completed jobs, pays reliably and does not no-show is being offered something no WhatsApp referral gives them: **protection from a bad customer**. Combined with visible escrow, that is the core of the provider proposition.

**REC Consequences must be real:** customers who fail to fund after acceptance twice lose the ability to book without prepayment; chronic no-shows pay a cancellation fee that goes **to the provider**, not to the platform.

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## Safety architecture (Brief §28)

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**REC This is the risk most likely to be underweighted, and the one with the worst human consequences.** Physical services put strangers in homes and send people — often young, often women — to addresses given by strangers.

**Customer safety** - Provider identity, photo and vehicle (where relevant) shown before arrival - Live job status; check-in/check-out with geotag - In-app emergency button routing to a staffed number during working hours - Never share the customer's full address until the job is funded and assigned - Post-job report channel that is prominent, not buried

**Provider safety — equally important and usually forgotten** - Provider sees the customer's verification level and history **before accepting** - Providers may decline any job, always, with no ranking penalty - **Share-my-trip** to a trusted contact for on-site jobs - Check-in/check-out with a missed-check-out escalation to ops - Right to leave immediately and be paid in full if a site is unsafe or the customer is abusive - **REC No lone female provider dispatched to a customer-absent residential job without an explicit opt-in and a check-in protocol.** This should be policy before it is ever tested.

**Prohibited and restricted - Prohibited:** anything involving minors unsupervised, medical/clinical services, legal advice, security services, firearms, money handling for third parties, anything requiring a professional licence you have not verified. - **LEGAL — COUNSEL REQUIRED**: childcare, elder care, health-adjacent services, domestic-worker placement, property representation, financial or tax services. Each needs a written view before the category opens.

**REC** Treat any safety incident as a company-level event with founder involvement, a defined escalation path, and a decision made within hours — not a support ticket. Have the protocol written before you need it.

## Disputes (Brief §24)

The five-tier ladder from the original blueprint survives and generalises:

|               |                                                         |         |
|---------------|---------------------------------------------------------|---------|
| L0 Self-serve | – rework request inside the included allowance          | 0–24h   |
| L1 Guided     | – structured claim + evidence, 48h to respond           |         |
| L2 Auto       | – objective rules decide (timestamps, evidence, timers) | instant |
| L3 Mediation  | – platform proposes a split; both accept → binding      | 72h     |
| L4 Adjudicate | – trained ops decides on an evidence rubric             | 5 days  |

**Auto-resolution rules —** **REC** publish these in advance; predictability is most of perceived fairness:

| Condition                                  | Outcome                                               |
|--------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| Provider no-show, no contact               | 100% refund; reliability penalty                      |
| Evidence complete, customer silent 5 days  | <b>Auto-approve, release to provider</b>              |
| Customer cancels >24h before scheduled     | Full refund                                           |
| Customer cancels <24h before               | 50% to provider (travel and lost slot are real costs) |
| Customer cancels after provider checked in | 100% to provider                                      |
| Materials receipted, work incomplete       | Materials settled; labour prorated                    |
| Evidence missing or ungeotagged            | No release until supplied                             |
| Scope disagreement                         | Written scope governs; unwritten claims fail          |

**REC** The asymmetry principle: place the burden of proof on whoever controls the evidence. The provider controls evidence of the work; the customer controls evidence of access, materials supplied and instructions given. Neither should be asked to prove a negative.

## Fraud (Brief §26)

**REC** Ranked by expected loss in this specific market:

| # | Threat                                                 | Primary control                                                 |
|---|--------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 | <b>Disintermediation</b>                               | Value-based retention ( 08 ) — not policing                     |
| 2 | <b>Provider bribed by a third party (agency fraud)</b> | Structured evidence, dual coverage, outcome follow-up           |
| 3 | Fabricated evidence (recycled or staged photos)        | In-app capture, geotag, hashing, perceptual duplicate detection |



| #  | Threat                                     | Primary control                                                 |
|----|--------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| 4  | Fake providers / stolen identity           | ID + liveness + M-Pesa name match                               |
| 5  | Materials-money theft                      | Escrowed, receipted materials milestone                         |
| 6  | Customer refuses to pay for completed work | Escrow + 5-day auto-release                                     |
| 7  | Theft from a customer's home               | Tier 2/3 verification, insurance partnership, incident protocol |
| 8  | Review manipulation / collusion rings      | Settled-transaction gating, graph analysis on repeated pairs    |
| 9  | Account takeover / SIM swap                | 24h hold and re-verification on payout-detail change            |
| 10 | Fake customers wasting provider time       | Customer verification + funding-before-dispatch                 |

**REC** The keystone control is unchanged from the original blueprint: **reputation and reviews derive only from escrow-settled transactions.** It makes fraud expensive, traceable and reversible, and it is nearly free to enforce.

# Payment Architecture

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## What carries over unchanged

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The payment architecture from the original blueprint survives essentially intact, because it was designed around a constraint that has not changed: **FACT** processing retail payments, operating digital wallets or acting as an aggregator in Kenya requires **CBK authorisation as a Payment Service Provider** under the National Payment System Act 2011 and NPS Regulations 2014, with obligations to segregate client funds via trust or escrow structures. (CBK)

### **REC** The unchanged design rules:

1. **Launch on a licensed aggregator** (IntaSend / Paystack / Pesapal / Flutterwave) so the regulated float never sits in your name. You are a merchant instructing payments, not a payments business.
2. **Escrow is always bound to one identified transaction.** No general-purpose stored balance.
3. **Hard 60-day maximum escrow life**, then force-resolve.
4. **Auto-sweep provider earnings to M-Pesa.** No idle balances.
5. **Never pay interest on or invest held funds.**
6. **Double-entry ledger, reconciled daily against the aggregator, owned by a named person.**
7. **Business-Pays B2C tariff** — **FACT** M-Pesa's Business Pays option means the customer receives KSh 0 in deductions on amounts from KSh 1 to KSh 250,000. Absorb it. "KSh 6,000 means KSh 6,000 in your phone" is worth far more than the KSh 40-60 it costs.
8. **Static-IP constraint applies.** **FACT** Vercel uses dynamic outbound IPs; Daraja go-live typically involves whitelisting production server IPs. The aggregator resolves this — one more reason it is the right V1 choice. ( 12 )

**LEGAL — COUNSEL REQUIRED** Whether this architecture makes you a PSP is a written-opinion question, not a judgement call. Unchanged from the original blueprint and still the first thing to resolve.

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## What changes for a services marketplace

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### 1. Money moves before the work, not after the brief

In the creator marketplace, funding and delivery were days apart and both remote. Here, a provider **travels to a location and incurs cost before any deliverable exists**. That changes three things:

**REC Fund before dispatch, always.** No provider is given an address until escrow is confirmed. This protects the provider from wasted trips and the customer from unfunded no-shows, and it makes the "customer failed to fund" failure mode impossible rather than merely penalised.

**REC Release travel/callout components at check-in, not at completion.** A provider who has physically arrived has earned the callout. Withholding it until a customer approves days later is the kind of unfairness that loses supply.

## 2. Materials money is a distinct escrow stage

The largest trust failure in Kenyan trade work, and unmodelled by every competitor I found.

|                    |                                                                                                                 |
|--------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| MATERIALS_ADVANCED | → platform releases the agreed materials budget to the provider (or pays the supplier directly, where possible) |
| MATERIALS_RECEIVED | → provider uploads receipts + photos of goods on site<br>unused balance returns to the customer automatically   |

**REC Three rules:** the materials budget is agreed **in writing before work starts**; receipts are a **release condition** for the labour milestone, not a courtesy; and unused funds return automatically rather than on request. This protects the customer from theft and inflation, and — per Lynk's class-mistrust finding — protects the honest fundi from suspicion, which matters equally.

## 3. Recurring transactions need per-occurrence escrow

**REC Never take a large upfront payment for a series.** A customer booking quarterly property checks funds **each occurrence** shortly before it happens.

Two reasons, one commercial and one regulatory: prepaid multi-month balances are exactly the stored-value pattern that draws licensing scrutiny; and per-occurrence funding means a customer can stop at any time, which paradoxically increases willingness to start.

## 4. Payment structures by transaction size

| Value                   | Structure                                                                                |
|-------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| < KSh 5,000             | 100% escrowed, single release on approval                                                |
| KSh 5,000–25,000        | Callout/travel released at check-in; balance on approval                                 |
| > KSh 25,000            | Milestones: 30% on scope agreement, materials as a discrete stage, balance on completion |
| Recurring               | Per occurrence                                                                           |
| Representation (Tier 3) | 100% escrowed; released only on complete structured evidence                             |

## The failure matrix

| Scenario                    | Escrow outcome         | Provider record                                   | Customer record           |
|-----------------------------|------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|---------------------------|
| Provider no-show            | 100% refund            | Reliability penalty; 3 in 90 days<br>→ suspension | Free reassignment offered |
| Provider late, work fine    | Full release           | On-time % affected                                | —                         |
| Customer cancels >24h ahead | 100% refund            | —                                                 | No penalty                |
| Customer cancels <24h ahead | <b>50% to provider</b> | —                                                 | Cancellation rate ↑       |

| Scenario                             | Escrow outcome                               | Provider record     | Customer record       |
|--------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|---------------------|-----------------------|
| Customer cancels after check-in      | <b>100% to provider</b>                      | —                   | Cancellation rate ↑ ↑ |
| Customer silent 5 days post-evidence | <b>Auto-release to provider</b>              | —                   | Non-response logged   |
| Work incomplete                      | Prorated by scope items completed            | Quality flag        | —                     |
| Materials taken, no work             | Materials clawed back; labour zero           | <b>Fraud review</b> | Full refund           |
| Site unsafe, provider withdraws      | <b>100% to provider</b>                      | No penalty          | Reviewed              |
| Evidence missing                     | Held pending                                 | —                   | —                     |
| Platform error                       | <b>Both paid in full from platform funds</b> | —                   | —                     |

**REC** The last row is a budget line, not a hypothetical. Pay both sides and reconcile later. It is the cheapest reputation insurance available.

## KYC, tiered to value

| Tier | Trigger                             | Required                                        |
|------|-------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| 0    | Signup                              | Phone OTP on an M-Pesa-registered number        |
| 1    | First paid job                      | Full name matching M-Pesa registration          |
| 2    | Cumulative KSh 50,000               | National ID + liveness; ID-to-M-Pesa name match |
| 3    | Cumulative KSh 500,000, or business | KRA PIN; business registration where applicable |

**REC** The M-Pesa name-match check remains the highest-value fraud control per shilling spent. M-Pesa registration is already ID-bound; requiring the payout name to match the KYC name defeats most mule-account and takeover patterns in one step.

## Tax

**FACT** Kenya applies a **5% withholding tax on digital content monetisation** for residents (20% non-residents), effective 1 July 2023, with Meta withholding from January 2026 and Google/YouTube from September 2026 earnings.

**REC** Note carefully: that regime is specific to *digital content monetisation*. It is directly relevant to the creator vertical. **LEGAL — COUNSEL REQUIRED** Whether and how withholding applies to a plumber's labour, an inspector's fee, or a platform's service fee is a **different question with a different answer**, and one of the clearest examples in this document of where the pivot widens the regulatory surface. Get a written view covering: withholding obligations by service type; VAT on the platform fee and on the

underlying service; VAT registration threshold and timing; and the treatment of materials pass-through, which is **ASSUMPTION** likely not your revenue but must be presented correctly in the ledger either way.

**REC Build the capability, keep it switchable per category and residency, and generate withholding certificates automatically.** Handling providers' tax paperwork is a genuine benefit the informal economy cannot offer — and an honest reason to transact on-platform.

## The ledger

Unchanged and still non-negotiable from commit one:

Accounts

customer\_receivable

escrow\_held

platform\_revenue

provider\_payable

materials\_held

payment\_costs

tax\_withheld

insurance\_reserve

Invariant, always:

$$\sum \text{escrow\_held} + \sum \text{materials\_held} + \sum \text{provider\_payable} \\ == \text{aggregator settlement balance}$$

**REC materials\_held and insurance\_reserve are new accounts, and both are liabilities, not revenue.** Booking a materials advance as revenue is an easy and expensive accounting error to make early. Get the chart of accounts reviewed by an accountant before the first transaction, not after the first audit.

# Liquidity, Density and Growth

## Cold start: which side first?

**REC Neither. Sell completed jobs by hand, one at a time, before building anything.** This is unchanged from the original blueprint and more important here, because a services failure is physical and public: a no-show at someone's home generates a story that travels.

Weeks 1–4    Sell and deliver 20 jobs manually. WhatsApp, a phone, a spreadsheet.  
                  Recruit ONLY the providers those 20 jobs need – perhaps 8 people.  
 Weeks 5–8    40 more. Write down every price, objection, failure and dispute.  
 Weeks 9–12   Build the product from what you wrote down. Not before.

**FACT** Lynk pivoted its operating model repeatedly searching for one that worked in Nairobi, and had to build its own academy after training partnerships failed. **REC Assume you will be wrong about the operating model too, and buy that discovery cheaply — with 60 manual jobs, not with 9 months of engineering.**

## The Deal Desk, generalised — your best cold-start weapon (Brief \$31)

The strongest idea in the original blueprint transfers directly, and is stronger here.

A provider already has a customer.  
       ↓  
 "Let's run it through the platform so we both have protection."  
       ↓  
 Platform: agreed scope + escrow + evidence + guaranteed payout + a verified record  
       ↓  
 Provider pays 5%. Customer pays 0%. Customer is now onboarded, free.

**REC Why this matters more in services than it did in the creator market:**

- **It solves the two-sided cold start by not having one.** Both parties already exist and already agreed.
- **It acquires customers at approximately zero CAC**, and they arrive pre-trusting because their own provider vouched for the platform.
- **It generates real price data** — the input every "productised outcome" price in this document currently lacks.
- **It converts your biggest threat into revenue.** Rather than policing off-platform behaviour, you monetise it.
- **FACT** Precedent: Upwork Direct Contracts at 5%.

**REC The provider pitch is one sentence: "Never chase a payment again. 5%."** For a fundi who has been stiffed — and most have — that is a stronger proposition than lead generation.

**REC** The customer pitch is also one sentence: *"It costs you nothing, and your money is only released when you're happy."*

## Disintermediation — the honest analysis (Brief \$27, \$30)

**REC** You cannot prevent it. Stop trying. Design so that leaving is a bad trade, and choose categories where it is a bad trade naturally.

Your brief asks for the answer to be *"Why would you leave?"* rather than *"Don't share your number."* Correct. Here is the honest inventory.

**Where leakage is structurally unwinnable:** Recurring, local, same-provider, in-home services — cleaning, mama fua, gardening, nannying. By the third visit the relationship is direct and both parties save your fee. **REC** The answer is not a feature. The answer is to not launch there. This is the primary reason those categories are excluded in 00 \$6.

**Where leakage is structurally weak — build here:**

| Category                                            | Why the customer stays                                                                                                                                       |
|-----------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Remote-principal / representation</b>            | The customer has <b>no basis to trust the individual</b> . The platform <i>is</i> the trust. Going direct reintroduces exactly the risk they paid to remove. |
| <b>Episodic trades</b> (plumbing, painting, moving) | Different problem, different specialist, months apart. The customer's memory is of <i>the platform</i> , not the person.                                     |
| <b>High-value one-offs</b>                          | The guarantee, dispute cover and insurance matter more than 15%.                                                                                             |
| <b>Business services</b>                            | Invoices, receipts, contracts, rights and VAT records have real value to a business buyer.                                                                   |

**Retention mechanisms worth building, in order of strength:**

1. **Escrow and the guarantee.** Off-platform there is no recourse; the whole value is the recourse.
2. **Descending repeat fees** — 15% → 10% → 8% for the same customer-provider pair. Attacks leakage at the exact moment it is most tempting: right after a good first job.
3. **The Deal Desk at 5%** — the pressure valve.
4. **Records that matter:** receipts, warranty tracking, service history on a property, tax documentation.
5. **Workmanship guarantee** — a 30-day platform-backed guarantee simply does not exist off-platform. **REC** This is the strongest single anti-leakage feature for trade work and should be introduced with Vertical 3.
6. **ASSUMPTION Insurance attachment, later.** **FACT** Kandua was acquired by an insurer having built embedded financial services — evidence the attachment is real, but it requires partnership and regulatory work far beyond MVP.

**REC** Detection is worth building only to inform pricing, never for punishment. Aggressive enforcement in a market where both sides can transact on M-Pesa in ten seconds produces resentment and no compliance. Measure repeat rate per pair; if it collapses after job one, that is a pricing signal, not a policing signal.

## Geographic density (Brief §35)

**REC** **Think in travel time, not administrative geography.** Nairobi traffic makes 8km unbookable at 5pm. Model `country → county → town → ward`, with a **travel-time matrix by time of day** rather than straight-line distance.

**REC** **Launch corridor, not city:** Westlands, Parklands, Kilimani, Kileleshwa, Lavington, Karen. High-value property, dense SMEs, concentrated diaspora-owned rentals, providers can cross the corridor in reasonable time.

**REC** **The density rule:** do not open a new area until the current one sustains **≥5 verified providers per active service with <24h availability**. A thin footprint in six areas reads as an empty product everywhere; a dense footprint in one reads as a real service.

**FACT** **SweepSouth's exit from Kenya and Nigeria is the cautionary case** — home-services capability is local operational competence, not software, and it does not travel. That protects you from outside entrants and constrains your own expansion equally.

## Provider acquisition (Brief §31)

| Channel                               | <b>ASSUMPTION</b> Cost per active earning provider | Quality | Notes                                                                                   |
|---------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|---------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Founder hand-recruitment</b>       | Time                                               | ★★★★★   | The only channel for the first 30                                                       |
| <b>Deal Desk</b>                      | ~0                                                 | ★★★★★   | They arrive with a customer                                                             |
| Provider referrals                    | KSh 500                                            | ★★★★★   | Paid on the referee's first <i>settled</i> job                                          |
| Earnings-proof content                | KSh 300                                            | ★★★★    | A real M-Pesa message from a real provider                                              |
| Trade associations, jua kali clusters | KSh 800                                            | ★★★★    | For Vertical 3                                                                          |
| TVET / polytechnic partnerships       | KSh 1,000                                          | ★★★     | <b>FACT</b> Lynk's vocational partnerships never took off — expect this to underperform |
| Facebook/TikTok ads                   | KSh 2,000                                          | ★★      | Volume, low intent                                                                      |

**REC** **Never pay on signup. Pay on the referee's first settled job.** Signup bounties reliably attract organised fraud; earning-gated rewards do not, because gaming them requires moving real money through a KYC'd rail.

**REC** **For the launch vertical, recruit small and pay well.** Twenty excellent verifiers beat two hundred mediocre ones. This supply pool is the product; treat recruitment like hiring, not like onboarding.

## Customer acquisition (Brief §32)

**REC** **For the diaspora wedge, the channels are unusually concentrated and unusually cheap:**



| Channel                                                  | Why                                                                                                                                                       |
|----------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Diaspora Facebook and WhatsApp groups</b>             | Where scam warnings already circulate. Enter by being useful — publish a free "how to avoid rental and land scams" guide — not by advertising.            |
| <b>Kenyan diaspora SACCOs, chamas, investment groups</b> | Members are actively buying property remotely. Partner rather than advertise.                                                                             |
| <b>Diaspora churches and county associations</b>         | High-trust, referral-dense communities                                                                                                                    |
| <b>Content answering the exact fear</b>                  | "How to verify a Kilimani apartment before you send a deposit" — SEO against a query people are already typing in distress                                |
| <b>Property portals and agents</b>                       | <b>REC</b> <b>Careful.</b> An agent referring inspections has an obvious conflict of interest. Accept traffic; never let the seller choose the inspector. |
| <b>Provider storefronts</b>                              | Shared into the same groups                                                                                                                               |

**REC** **The highest-converting asset you can produce is a redacted real inspection report.** It shows a frightened remote buyer exactly what KSh 6,000 buys, which no amount of copy achieves.

## Growth loops (Brief §33, §34)

Ranked by how much I would actually invest:

- 1. Provider storefront distribution ★★★★★** Provider gets a bookable page → shares it → customers arrive → provider earns → shares more. Supply becomes your demand channel. Cheapest acquisition available.
- 2. Deal Desk conversion ★★★★★** Provider brings existing customer → customer experiences escrow → customer books someone else → that provider brings their customers. Converts the informal economy transaction by transaction.
- 3. Fear-relief referral ★★★★★** Customer avoids a scam → tells everyone. **ASSUMPTION** In diaspora communities a near-miss story travels further than a satisfied one. Build the share moment into the report delivery: *"Share this report."*
- 4. Earnings-proof loop ★★★★★** A real provider showing a real M-Pesa payment. Build a one-tap shareable receipt into the payout notification.
- 5. Recurring conversion ★★★★★** One-off job → "set up quarterly" → recurring GMV.
- 6. Density loop ★★★★★** Enough providers in Kilimani → faster response → better reviews → more customers in Kilimani. Manage by neighbourhood, not city.
- 7. Evidence-as-marketing ★★★** Redacted reports and before/after sets become the content engine.
- 8. Landlord bridge ★★★** Diaspora buyer completes purchase → becomes a landlord → needs ongoing management. **REC** **The single most valuable conversion in the model:** it turns a 2×/year customer into a quarterly one.
- 9. Trade-cluster loop ★★★** One respected fundi joins → his cluster follows. Supply in trades is socially networked.

**10. Records loop ★★** Service history accumulating on a property makes the platform the system of record for that asset. Slow, and genuinely sticky.

## Referrals (Brief §31)

| Programme                  | Reward                                        | Trigger                            |
|----------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|------------------------------------|
| Customer → customer        | KSh 500 credit each                           | Referee's first <b>settled</b> job |
| <b>Provider → customer</b> | <b>3% of that customer's GMV for 6 months</b> | First settled job; capped          |
| Provider → provider        | KSh 500                                       | Referee's first settled job        |
| Diaspora community partner | Revenue share, contractual                    | Ongoing                            |

**REC** The provider→customer reward is deliberately the most generous, because a provider who brings a paying customer is worth far more than one who brings another provider. Supply is not your constraint; trusted demand is.

# The Verticals Assessed

## The scoring framework

Scored 1–5 against the criteria in your brief §20, weighted by what actually determines survival.

**ASSUMPTION** Scores are my judgement, not measured data.

| Criterion                           | Weight | Why                                                                 |
|-------------------------------------|--------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| AOV above the KSh 5,000 line        | ×3     | Below it, no fee survives the payment rail plus one support contact |
| Leakage resistance                  | ×3     | Determines whether repeat GMV exists at all                         |
| Trust deficit worth paying to close | ×2     | Determines whether the fee is defensible                            |
| Willingness to prepay               | ×2     | Escrow is the product; no prepay, no product                        |
| Supply verifiability & cost         | ×2     | <b>FACT</b> Lynk's cost centre                                      |
| Completion verifiable remotely      | ×2     | Determines whether ops can scale                                    |
| Frequency                           | ×1     | Matters, but not at the cost of the above                           |
| Regulatory simplicity               | ×1     |                                                                     |
| Safety exposure (inverted)          | ×1     |                                                                     |

| Vertical                               | AOV | Leak | Trust | Prepay | Supply | Verif | Freq | Reg | Safe | Score    |
|----------------------------------------|-----|------|-------|--------|--------|-------|------|-----|------|----------|
| <b>Remote-principal services</b>       | 4   | 5    | 5     | 5      | 4      | 5     | 2    | 3   | 3    | ★<br>4.4 |
| <b>Business &amp; creator services</b> | 4   | 3    | 3     | 4      | 5      | 5     | 3    | 4   | 5    | 4.0      |
| <b>High-value fundi work</b>           | 4   | 4    | 5     | 3      | 2      | 3     | 2    | 3   | 3    | 3.5      |
| Moving & logistics                     | 4   | 4    | 4     | 3      | 3      | 3     | 1    | 3   | 3    | 3.4      |
| Personal services (beauty, tutoring)   | 2   | 1    | 2     | 3      | 3      | 3     | 4    | 3   | 3    | 2.4      |
| <b>House cleaning</b>                  | 2   | 1    | 3     | 3      | 3      | 2     | 5    | 3   | 2    | 2.3      |
| <b>Errands &amp; delivery</b>          | 1   | 2    | 2     | 3      | 4      | 4     | 4    | 3   | 4    | 2.3      |
| <b>Mama fua / domestic</b>             | 1   | 1    | 3     | 2      | 2      | 2     | 5    | 1   | 2    | 1.9      |

**REC** The ranking inverts the intuition in your brief. The categories you led with — mama fua, cleaning, errands — score lowest. They score lowest because of the two triple-weighted criteria: they sit below the KSh 5,000 line and they leak almost completely. High frequency cannot compensate for a fee that does not cover its own payment costs.

## 1. Remote-Principal Services — the recommended wedge

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**What it is.** Being someone's verified eyes, hands and judgement in Kenya when they cannot be there: property inspection before a deposit, viewing on their behalf, quarterly checks on a rental, supervising a fundi, collecting documents, verifying goods before payment, attending to a family matter.

**Why it wins on the criteria that matter:** - **FACT** The trust deficit is documented and worsening — housing scams surging in Kilimani, Kileleshwa, Jamhuri and Lavington, exploiting the deposit convention; diaspora investors targeted **specifically because distance makes due diligence nearly impossible**; press guidance concluding that a *"trusted, verifiable representative in Kenya"* is among the most effective protections available. - **FACT** The buyer population is large and demonstrably moves money: **US\$5.04B remitted in 2025**, CBK projecting **US\$5.24B for 2026**. - **Leakage resistance is structural**, not engineered: the customer has no relationship to fall back on. The platform is the trust. - **Completion is verifiable remotely** — the deliverable *is* evidence, so escrow and dispute resolution work cleanly. - **Supply is largely fungible** across job types, which is the escape from "every category is a different company."

**The honest risks:** - **ASSUMPTION** **Market size unverified.** No source sizes willingness to pay. **This is the first thing to test and it is cheap to test.** - **Agency fraud is the existential risk** ( 06 ). A bribed inspector is worse than no inspector. - Low frequency outside the property-owning segment. -

**LEGAL — COUNSEL REQUIRED** Property representation, and the boundary between reporting facts and giving professional opinion on title or valuation.

**REC** **Launch product: "Know Before You Pay" — KSh 6,000.** Geotagged photo set, video walkthrough, 12-point structured checklist, delivered within 48 hours. **ASSUMPTION** **Price to be validated in week one.**

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## 2. Business & Creator Services — Vertical 2, already designed

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The original blueprint, intact, in `archive-creator-marketplace/`. Everything in it remains valid **for this vertical**: storefronts, packages, UGC as the flagship, rights and licensing, the watermark gate, campaign types, creator reputation.

**Why it stays and why it is second, not first:** high AOV, digital delivery, remote payment, zero physical safety risk, portfolio-assessable supply, genuinely exportable — but a **FACT** US\$2.1–3.0M measured local market, which is why it cannot be the company. **REC** **It is an excellent second vertical and a poor first one**, because it does not compound with the trust wedge as directly as property services do, and because the buyer relationship is with businesses rather than the remote principals you will already be serving.

**REC** **Adjust the fee model.** The original 15%-on-top / 0%-to-provider design assumed digital work and a supply-acquisition war. Reconcile it with the cross-vertical model in 10.

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## 3. High-Value Fundi Work — Vertical 3

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Repairs, installation, painting, moving, appliance and electrical work. **Only jobs above KSh 5,000.**

**Why it is genuinely attractive:** the trust deficit is severe and specific — overcharging, botched work, and above all the **materials advance** that disappears. **REC** **The materials escrow in 04 and 07 is a**

**real, buildable differentiator that no competitor models.** Episodic use means moderate leakage resistance. And it is the natural adjacency from property: the customer who just had a flat inspected needs it repaired.

**Why it is not first:** **FACT** Lynk's vetting and training costs forced it to build an academy, and its vocational partnerships failed. Competence assessment for trades is slow, expensive and does not transfer. Quality variance is high and quality control requires physical inspection. **FACT** Urban Company's lesson is that this vertical works *managed*, not as a light marketplace — which is a capital-intensive commitment you should make only with evidence.

**REC** **Enter with a narrow, productised set** — Fix My Leak, Paint My 1-Bed, Move My Flat — not "browse fundis." Fixed prices, defined inclusions, workmanship guarantee.

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## 4. Property Services — not a separate vertical; the spine of Vertical 1

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Your brief §7 asks me to think hard about property and to avoid becoming a listings site. **REC** **Agreed, and the conclusion is stronger than "add property services":**

**Property is not a category alongside the others. It is the demand engine for the entire wedge.** The property lifecycle generates the whole service catalogue:

|                               |                                                                                                     |
|-------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Considering a purchase/rental | → inspection, viewing, title-adjacent verification                                                  |
| Committing                    | → document collection, agent verification                                                           |
| Moving in                     | → cleaning, repairs, furniture assembly, internet setup                                             |
| Owning (recurring)            | → quarterly checks, tenant vetting, rent oversight, maintenance supervision, caretaker verification |
| Selling / letting             | → photography, listing content, viewings on your behalf                                             |

**REC** **Do not build listings, do not hold deposits, do not take a cut of rent or sale.** All three drag you into estate-agency and payments regulation, and the second is explicitly ruled out in 06. **Sell the human service required to navigate the asset** — which is exactly the framing in your brief, and it is correct.

**REC** **The landlord conversion is the most valuable transition in the business model:** a one-off inspection customer who buys the property becomes a **recurring quarterly customer**, converting the wedge's weakest attribute (frequency) into its strongest.

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## 5. Home Services below KSh 5,000 — excluded

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Cleaning, mama fua, laundry, gardening, errands, small deliveries.

**REC** **Excluded from the plan entirely, for now.** Below the KSh 5,000 line; highest leakage of any category; **FACT** the categories on which Lynk and SweepSouth both foundered in this exact city; and for domestic work specifically, **FACT** a gazetted minimum wage of KSh 18,047/month and over two million informally employed workers create **LEGAL — COUNSEL REQUIRED** employment-classification exposure quite unlike booking a tradesperson.

**REC** **The only conditions under which these open later:** per-order human cost has been engineered to near zero, basket size has been raised through bundling, and you are prepared to run

them **managed** rather than as a listing. That is Urban Company's model and it is a different company with a different balance sheet.

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## Final launch recommendation (Brief \$60)

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**Launch with Remote-Principal Services, in the Nairobi property corridor, with property verification as the entry product.**

**Add Business & Creator Services in month 6. Add high-value fundi work in month 12.**

**Never add cleaning, mama fua or errands unless the economics are re-proven from scratch.**

### Why this ordering and not the reverse:

1. It is the **only** vertical that scores well on both triple-weighted criteria.
2. It is the only one where **the trust deficit is documented in the press rather than assumed by you.**
3. Its buyer earns hard currency and already sends money blind.
4. Its supply is the cheapest to verify — integrity and documentation, not a trade skill.
5. It generates the natural adjacency into fundi work (Vertical 3) and landlord recurrence.
6. **Nobody is serving it.** Every competitor found — Lynk, SweepSouth, My-Fundi, Balozy, Kalinoi, Juakali Hub — is building for the resident who is standing in their own home.

# Business Model and Unit Economics

## Why the original pricing does not survive the pivot

The creator blueprint recommended **15% on top, paid by the brand, 0% from the provider**. That was right for a market where supply was the scarce side, deliverables were digital, and prices were listed.

**REC** It does not survive contact with services, for three reasons:

1. **Quote-based work has no listed price to add 15% to.** A fundi quoting KSh 8,000 will simply quote KSh 8,000 knowing the customer pays KSh 9,200, and the "provider keeps 100%" promise becomes theatre.
2. **In services, demand is the scarce side, not supply.** Kenya has abundant providers and scarce trusted demand. Giving away the provider fee buys you the wrong thing.
3. **A single rate cannot span a KSh 3,500 repair and a KSh 50,000 project.**

## The recommended model

**REC** A two-sided but asymmetric fee, transparent on both sides, varying by vertical.

Customer pays: service price + service fee (8–12%, shown as a line item)  
 Provider pays: commission (5–10%, shown gross → net in the app)  
 Blended take: 15–20%, varying by vertical

| Vertical                                    | Customer fee | Provider fee | Blended    | Rationale                                                                              |
|---------------------------------------------|--------------|--------------|------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Remote-principal / verification</b>      | <b>12%</b>   | <b>8%</b>    | <b>20%</b> | Highest value delivered; customer is buying assurance, not labour; hard-currency buyer |
| Business & creator                          | 12%          | 0%           | 12%        | Keep the archived promise — supply war is real in this vertical                        |
| Fundi / trade                               | 8%           | 10%          | 18%        | Provider gains most (guaranteed payment, materials protection, disputes)               |
| <b>Deal Desk</b> (provider brings customer) | <b>0%</b>    | <b>5%</b>    | <b>5%</b>  | Platform contributed no demand                                                         |
| <b>Repeat, same pair, 2nd job</b>           | 6%           | 6%           | <b>12%</b> | Anti-leakage                                                                           |
| <b>Repeat, same pair, 3rd+</b>              | 5%           | 5%           | <b>10%</b> | Anti-leakage                                                                           |
| Recurring series                            | 5%           | 5%           | <b>10%</b> | Retention over extraction                                                              |

**REC** Four principles that must not be compromised:

1. **Never a hidden provider fee.** The app always shows *"Job KSh 8,000 · Platform 10% –KSh 800 · You receive KSh 7,200"* before acceptance. **FACT** Kenyan providers' loudest grievance with agencies and brokers is opaque deduction; replicating it destroys the supply proposition instantly.
2. **Never charge for leads.** **FACT** Thumbtack does \$400M charging \$8-150 per lead shared with 4-5 pros. It works commercially and it is wrong here: it extracts from providers who cannot afford it, decouples revenue from completed work, and produces no completion data — which is your entire strategic asset.
3. **Descending repeat fees are a cost of retention, not lost revenue.** The alternative is not 15% on job two; it is 0% on job two, off-platform.
4. **REC Materials pass-through is not revenue and not GMV.** Report it separately or you will flatter your numbers and mislead yourself.

## The KSh 5,000 line, derived

**ASSUMPTION** Cost inputs are estimates requiring real quotes. Payment costs use the earlier verified structure: collection ~1.5% at low volume, B2C payout ~1% plus a fixed per-transaction cost, business-absorbed.

| Job value         | Blended fee | Revenue | Payment cost | Gross | Cost to serve | Contribution            |
|-------------------|-------------|---------|--------------|-------|---------------|-------------------------|
| KSh 800           | 18%         | 144     | 68           | 76    | 150-300       | –74 to –224             |
| KSh 1,500         | 18%         | 270     | 78           | 192   | 150-350       | –158 to +42             |
| KSh 3,000         | 18%         | 540     | 98           | 442   | 200-400       | +42 to +242             |
| <b>KSh 5,000</b>  | 18%         | 900     | 121          | 779   | 200-400       | <b>+379 to +579</b>     |
| <b>KSh 8,000</b>  | 18%         | 1,440   | 155          | 1,285 | 250-400       | <b>+885 to +1,035</b>   |
| <b>KSh 22,000</b> | 18%         | 3,960   | 314          | 3,646 | 300-450       | <b>+3,196 to +3,346</b> |

**Cost to serve** = allocated support, trust & safety, dispute handling and QC per completed job. **REC** For physical services with any human touch, assume KSh 200-400 in year one. It falls with automation and standardisation; it never reaches zero while people enter homes.

**The line sits at roughly KSh 5,000.** Below it, one support contact consumes the entire margin. Above KSh 8,000 the model is comfortable.

## Three scale scenarios

**ASSUMPTION** Illustrative, not forecasts.

### Scenario 1 — Month 9: proving the wedge

Completed jobs / month

400



|                                                  |                          |
|--------------------------------------------------|--------------------------|
| Average job value                                | <b>KSh 7,500</b>         |
| <b>GMV</b>                                       | <b>KSh 3,000,000</b>     |
| Revenue @ 19% blended                            | 570,000                  |
| Payment costs                                    | (95,000)                 |
| Ops, support, T&S (5 FTE @ 85,000)               | (425,000)                |
| <b>Gross profit</b>                              | <b>50,000 (9%)</b>       |
| Engineering (4 @ 260,000), marketing, G&A, infra | (2,090,000)              |
| <b>Net</b>                                       | <b>–KSh 2,040,000/mo</b> |

## Scenario 2 — Month 24: two verticals, Nairobi

|                                                   |                          |
|---------------------------------------------------|--------------------------|
| Completed jobs / month                            | 3,000                    |
| Average job value                                 | <b>KSh 11,000</b>        |
| <b>GMV</b>                                        | <b>KSh 33,000,000</b>    |
| Revenue @ 17% blended (repeat discounts biting)   | 5,610,000                |
| Payment costs @ negotiated rates                  | (660,000)                |
| Ops, support, T&S (16 FTE @ 90,000)               | (1,440,000)              |
| <b>Gross profit</b>                               | <b>3,510,000 (63%)</b>   |
| Engineering (10 @ 300,000), marketing, G&A, infra | (7,300,000)              |
| <b>Net</b>                                        | <b>–KSh 3,790,000/mo</b> |

## Scenario 3 — Month 42: three verticals, two cities

|                                                                |                                       |
|----------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| Completed jobs / month                                         | 15,000                                |
| Average job value                                              | <b>KSh 13,000</b>                     |
| <b>GMV</b>                                                     | <b>KSh 195,000,000 (~US\$1.5M/mo)</b> |
| Revenue @ 16% blended                                          | 31,200,000                            |
| Payment costs                                                  | (3,510,000)                           |
| Ops, support, T&S (45 FTE @ 100,000)                           | (4,500,000)                           |
| <b>Gross profit</b>                                            | <b>23,190,000 (74%)</b>               |
| Engineering (28 @ 350,000), marketing, G&A, T&S tooling, infra | (21,000,000)                          |
| <b>Net</b>                                                     | <b>+KSh 2,190,000/mo</b>              |

## What the models actually say

**1. Breakeven sits around KSh 120-150M GMV/month** — roughly **10,000-12,000 completed jobs at KSh 12,000+**. That is a serious business and a long road. Anyone modelling breakeven at Scenario 2 is modelling a smaller team than this business needs.

**2. Cost to serve per job must fall roughly 3× between Scenario 1 and 3** (from ~KSh 1,060 to ~KSh 300 all-in ops per job). If it does not, Scenario 3 is loss-making. **REC** **Make cost-to-serve-per-completed-job a board metric from month one.**

**3. AOV remains the dominant lever, exactly as in the original blueprint.** At Scenario 2 volumes:

| AOV        | GMV   | Revenue | Gross profit |
|------------|-------|---------|--------------|
| KSh 6,000  | 18.0M | 3.06M   | 960,000      |
| KSh 11,000 | 33.0M | 5.61M   | 3,510,000    |
| KSh 16,000 | 48.0M | 8.16M   | 6,060,000    |

**Same job count. Gross profit swings 6×.** This is why the vertical selection in 09 matters more than any pricing decision.

**4. Payment costs improve from ~17% to ~11% of revenue** with volume negotiation, but never disappear.

## Other revenue lines, honestly assessed

| Line                                          | Verdict                                                                                                                                      |
|-----------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Transaction fee</b>                        | ✓ Core, from day one                                                                                                                         |
| <b>Managed service</b> (+8-10%)               | ✓ Real, and it <i>is</i> the product at launch                                                                                               |
| <b>Recurring series</b>                       | ✓ The retention prize — lower rate, higher LTV                                                                                               |
| Business accounts (landlords, agencies, SMEs) | ✓ V2 — high AOV, low CAC                                                                                                                     |
| Deal Desk (5%)                                | ✓ From day one — cold-start weapon                                                                                                           |
| Verification-as-a-service to third parties    | ⚠ Interesting later; conflict-of-interest risk if the seller pays                                                                            |
| Premium placement                             | ✗ Corrupts ranking, which is the product                                                                                                     |
| Provider subscriptions                        | ✗ Not while supply is being acquired                                                                                                         |
| Lead fees                                     | ✗ <b>Never</b> — see principle 2                                                                                                             |
| Customer subscriptions                        | ✗ Frequency is too low to justify                                                                                                            |
| <b>Insurance attachment</b>                   | ⚠ <b>FACT</b> Kandua's realised exit was to an insurer — a genuine long-term line, requiring partnership and <b>LEGAL — COUNSEL REQUIRED</b> |

| Line                   | Verdict                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Lending / underwriting |  <b>REC</b> <b>Keep out of the plan and out of the pitch.</b> Per your own brief: serious regulatory and risk analysis required first |

## The metric that governs pricing

**REC** **Do not optimise take rate. Optimise GMV per active customer per year .**

$$\text{GMV per customer/yr} = \text{AOV} \times \text{jobs per year} \times \text{retention}$$

A 20% take rate on a customer who transacts once is worth less than 12% on one who transacts six times. Every pricing decision in the table above — descending repeat fees, cheap recurring, the 5% Deal Desk — trades rate for frequency deliberately. **In a market where both parties can leave in ten seconds via M-Pesa, that is the only trade that compounds.**

# MVP, Roadmap and Plan

## The test that comes before the MVP

**REC** Before writing a line of code, resolve the one assumption the entire strategy rests on.

**Will a diaspora Kenyan pay ~KSh 6,000 (~US\$46) for a verified stranger to inspect a property and produce an evidenced report before they send a deposit?**

**The 30-day validation, costing roughly KSh 150,000:**

| Week | Action                                                                                                                               | Decision gate                                                     |
|------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1    | 20 structured interviews in diaspora Facebook/WhatsApp groups. Ask about a <i>past</i> transaction, never a hypothetical future one. | Do $\geq 8$ report a specific near-miss, loss or unresolved fear? |
| 2    | Landing page + one product. Paid promotion into three diaspora groups. <b>Take real money.</b>                                       | Do $\geq 10$ people pay without speaking to a founder?            |
| 3-4  | <b>Deliver 10 inspections by hand.</b> Founders recruit and accompany 3 inspectors. Produce real reports.                            | Do $\geq 7$ customers say they would pay again and refer?         |

**REC** **The kill criterion, written down in advance:** if fewer than 10 people pay in week 2, the diaspora wedge is not validated and you should reassess against Vertical 2 (business & creator services) — where you already have a complete blueprint and a proven willingness to pay — rather than proceeding on hope.

**REC** **Do not skip this because it feels small.** **FACT** Lynk spent years pivoting operating models to find one that worked in Nairobi, and SweepSouth spent \$15M+ before exiting Kenya. Both would have been better served by cheaper, earlier disconfirmation.

## MVP — what it proves

Your brief lists ten proof points. **REC** **Only three of them can genuinely be tested in an MVP, and the rest follow from those:**

- 1. Customers will pay before the work.** (Escrow is accepted.)
- 2. Jobs complete to a standard that satisfies the customer.** (Supply and QC work.)
- 3. Customers come back.** (It is a business, not a favour.)

Everything else — provider willingness, satisfaction, per-transaction margin — is either obvious or a consequence.

### MVP feature set

**Customer (mobile web):** phone OTP · "what do you need?" free-text + 4 productised services · browse providers or let ops assign · book and pay via STK Push · **see escrow status** · track job status · receive

structured report / evidence · approve or dispute · rate provider · **rebook in one tap**.

**Provider (mobile web, offline-tolerant):** phone OTP · verification flow (ID + liveness + M-Pesa name match) · profile and storefront · accept/decline jobs · **see that funds are escrowed** · check-in with geotag · **in-app evidence capture** · submit · earnings view (pending / in escrow / paid).

**Platform:** escrow (fund → hold → release) · M-Pesa STK collection and B2C payout · **all timers, especially 5-day auto-approve** · structured job scope · structured evidence capture · two-sided reviews · **ops console** · double-entry ledger · WhatsApp notifications · manual dispute handling.

**Four productised services only:** Know Before You Pay (inspection) · Viewed For You · Landlord's Quarterly Check · Document Collection.

## NOT building — and why (Brief §41)

| Deferred                                   | Why                                                                                        |
|--------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Native mobile apps</b>                  | App-store friction kills a low-trust funnel. Mobile web; PWA if needed.                    |
| <b>100+ categories</b>                     | The failure mode of the predecessors. Four services.                                       |
| <b>AI matching / AI intake</b>             | No transaction data to train on. Ops reads requests manually — that <i>is</i> the spec.    |
| <b>"Just ask" free-text automation</b>     | Same. Humans first, taxonomy second, model third.                                          |
| Post-a-task bidding                        | <b>FACT</b> Lynk abandoned auction for standardisation. Don't rebuild what they discarded. |
| Quote-based work                           | MVP is fixed-price only. Quoting arrives with Vertical 3.                                  |
| Materials escrow                           | Not needed until fundi work. Designed now, built later.                                    |
| Recurring billing                          | Manual for the first 20 series.                                                            |
| Provider subscriptions / premium placement | Corrupts ranking before ranking is proven                                                  |
| Automated background checks                | <b>REC</b> Manual, documented, defensible claims only                                      |
| Insurance / lending / financial products   | Regulatory work far beyond MVP; keep out of the pitch                                      |
| Enterprise & agency accounts               | Serve manually                                                                             |
| Advanced analytics, loyalty, gamification  | Feel like progress, move nothing                                                           |
| Multi-city, multi-currency                 | One corridor, KES                                                                          |
| Complex logistics                          | Not the business                                                                           |

## Manual by design

| Function                       | Manual method                               | Automate at |
|--------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|-------------|
| Provider recruitment & vetting | Founders interview every provider in person | Never fully |
| Matching                       | Ops assigns by hand                         | 300 jobs/mo |

| Function                     | Manual method                                               | Automate at      |
|------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|------------------|
| Intake of free-text requests | Ops reads and structures                                    | 500 jobs/mo      |
| Report QC                    | <b>Ops reviews every report before the customer sees it</b> | 400 jobs/mo      |
| Disputes                     | Founder decides                                             | Never fully      |
| Recurring scheduling         | Ops calendar                                                | 20 active series |
| <b>Payouts</b>               | <b>Automated from day one — never manual</b>                | —                |

**REC Report QC is the one manual step to protect longest.** In the launch vertical the report *is* the product, and a single bad report is a customer who loses money.

## 90-day plan (Brief §61)

| Weeks       | Focus                                                                                                                             | Target                                        |
|-------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| <b>1-4</b>  | Validation sprint above. Incorporate. Start aggregator onboarding and legal opinions <b>in week 1</b> .                           | 10 paid inspections; go/no-go                 |
| <b>5-8</b>  | 40 more jobs, still manual. Recruit to 12 verified providers. Write down every price, failure and dispute. Build the ops console. | 50 cumulative jobs; KSh 350k GMV              |
| <b>9-12</b> | Ship MVP to existing users. Deal Desk live. First recurring series.                                                               | 120 jobs/mo; KSh 850k GMV; <b>≥30% repeat</b> |

**REC Judge the quarter on three numbers only:** completion rate (>90%), **repeat/referral rate (>30%)**, median time to payout (<2 hours). Nothing else matters yet.

## 12-month roadmap (Brief §62)

| Months       | Milestone               | Key additions                                                                             | Gate to proceed                            |
|--------------|-------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| <b>1-3</b>   | V0 — manual             | Validation, 50 jobs                                                                       | 30% repeat, >90% completion                |
| <b>4-6</b>   | V1 — MVP live           | Escrow, storefronts, evidence capture, ops console, Deal Desk                             | 300 jobs/mo, contribution-positive per job |
| <b>7-9</b>   | <b>Vertical 2 opens</b> | Business & creator services from the archive; business accounts; quote-based work         | 700 jobs/mo, AOV ≥ KSh 9,000               |
| <b>10-12</b> | Depth, not breadth      | Recurring engine, landlord accounts, workmanship guarantee, structured dispute automation | 1,200 jobs/mo, <b>≥40% repeat GMV</b>      |

**REC Notice what is absent: no new geography and no fundi vertical in year one.** Both are month 12+ decisions, gated on the repeat rate.

## V2 (months 12-24)

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Fundi vertical with materials escrow and workmanship guarantee · quote-based transactions · recurring at scale · agency/landlord/business accounts · LLM intake structuring (trained on real requests) · automated dispute rules · second corridor within Nairobi · insurance partnership exploration. **KPI:** repeat GMV %. **Risk:** vertical dilution — adding fundis before verification ops are boring and reliable. **Gate to V3:** KSh 30M GMV/month with positive contribution per job.

## V3 (months 24-42)

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Third city (Mombasa) · export corridor for Vertical 2 · learned matching on real outcome data · property service history as a durable record · **ASSUMPTION** embedded insurance attachment. **KPI:** GMV and contribution margin. **Risk:** premature geography. **REC** **Rule: do not enter a second city until the first is contribution-positive** — the discipline SweepSouth did not apply.

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## 3-year vision (Brief §63)

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**REC** Stated honestly, without the hockey stick:

By year three the realistic good outcome is **KSh 150-200M GMV per month across two cities and three verticals, approaching breakeven, with a verified record of several hundred thousand completed real-world jobs**. That is a real company. It is not a unicorn, and any plan that says otherwise at this stage is a plan that has not met Nairobi.

What that record makes possible — insurance attachment, provider financial products, becoming the system of record for property maintenance — is genuinely valuable and genuinely uncertain. **REC** **Treat it as upside in the narrative, never as the plan.**

# Technical and Data Architecture

## The stack — reconsidered, mostly confirmed

**REC** The previous recommendation holds, and the pivot strengthens rather than weakens it.

| Layer           | Choice                                                                         | Change from before                                      |
|-----------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| Frontend        | Next.js on Vercel, TypeScript                                                  | Unchanged                                               |
| <b>Database</b> | <b>PostgreSQL (Supabase)</b>                                                   | <b>Unchanged — and now more strongly indicated</b>      |
| Auth            | Supabase Auth, <b>phone OTP primary</b>                                        | Unchanged; more important — providers may have no email |
| Storage         | <b>Cloudflare R2</b> (evidence masters), Supabase Storage (avatars, KYC, PDFs) | Unchanged                                               |
| Video           | Cloudflare Stream                                                              | Now for evidence video and creator portfolios           |
| Payments        | Licensed aggregator behind a <code>PaymentProvider</code> interface            | Unchanged                                               |
| Jobs/timers     | Inngest                                                                        | Now driving more timers                                 |
| Notifications   | WhatsApp Business API, SMS, push                                               | Unchanged; WhatsApp even more central                   |
| Geo             | <b>PostGIS + a travel-time matrix</b>                                          | <b>Expanded — dispatch is now geographic</b>            |
| Ops console     | Build in week one                                                              | <b>Now non-negotiable</b>                               |

**Why Postgres is a stronger call now than it was for the creator marketplace:** the pivot adds geospatial dispatch, per-category reputation, recurring series with parent/child transactions, materials sub-ledgers and multi-vertical scope modelling. Every one of those needs joins, constraints and transactions. **REC** **Firestore was wrong before; it is now emphatically wrong.**

**FACT** **Two serverless constraints carry over unchanged:** Vercel's dynamic outbound IPs versus Daraja's production IP whitelisting (resolved by the aggregator), and Supabase transaction-mode pooling on port 6543 with a reduced application-side pool.

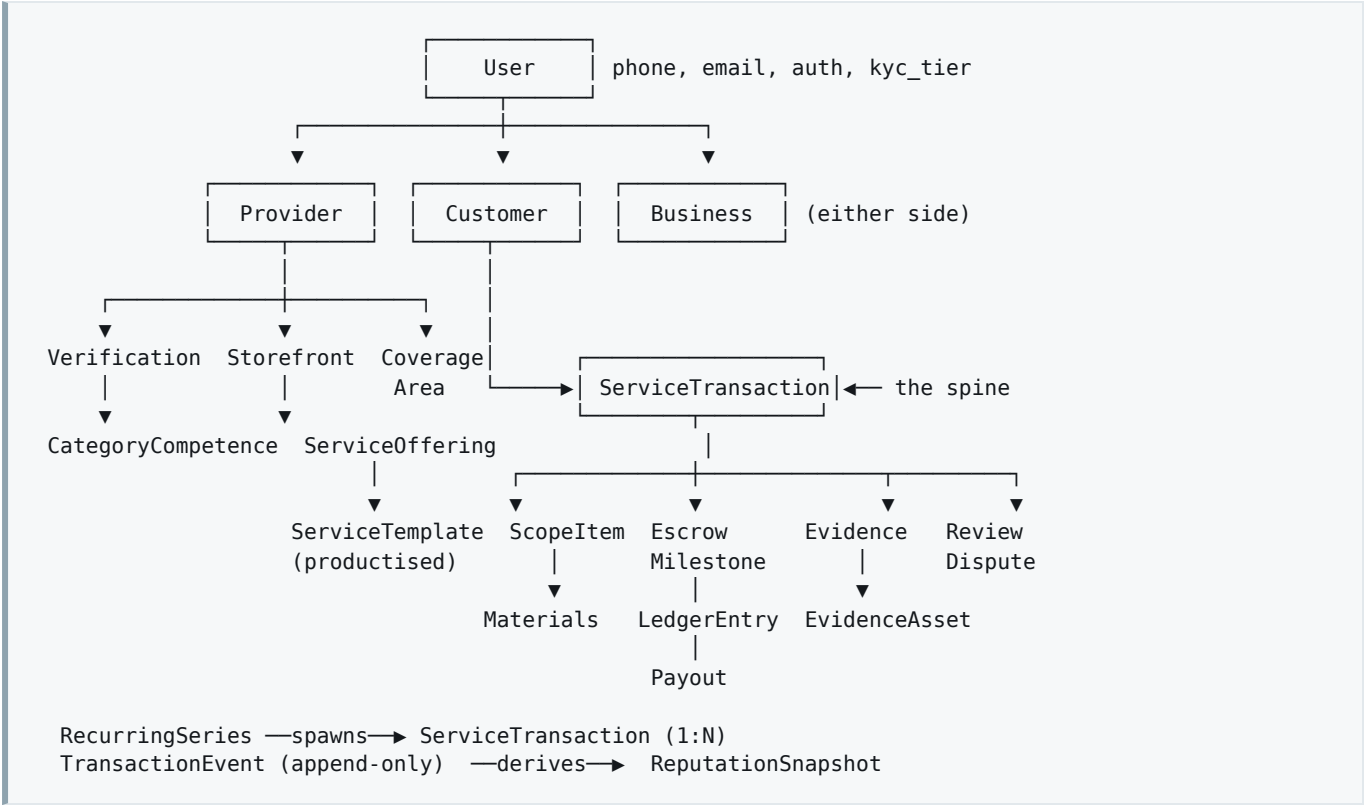
**REC** **Two additions specific to physical services:**

- 1. Offline-tolerant evidence capture.** A provider in a basement with no signal must complete a job and sync later. Local queue, background upload, idempotent submission. **FACT** SweepSouth's Kenya failure was attributed partly to slow and unstable technology in new markets — provider-side reliability is where that surfaces first.
- 2. Evidence integrity.** In-app capture only for Tier 3 work, EXIF and geotag captured at source, hash on upload, perceptual hashing to detect recycled photos across jobs. This is a trust control, not a storage decision. ( 06 )



# Core entities

**REC** The naming principle: nothing in the schema names a vertical. No inspection, no campaign, no cleaning\_job. A vertical is data, not structure.



## The tables that carry real design

```
service_transaction (
  id, customer_id, provider_id,
  service_template_id NULL,      -- NULL = custom/quoted job
  category_id,                  -- verification | trade | content | ...
  pricing_model,                -- fixed | quote | hourly | recurring | application
  fulfilment_mode,              -- remote_digital | on_site_present
                                -- | on_site_absent | at_provider | representation
  state, origin,                -- storefront | assigned | task_post | deal_desk | rebook
  currency,
  service_amount_minor,         -- what the provider is paid for labour
  materials_amount_minor,       -- pass-through: NOT revenue, NOT GMV
  customer_fee_minor, provider_fee_minor,
  location_id, scheduled_for, travel_time_estimate_s,
  parent_series_id NULL,
  funded_at, scheduled_at, checked_in_at, evidence_at, approved_at, settled_at,
  auto_approve_at,              -- evidence_at + 5 days
  escrow_expires_at             -- funded_at + 60 days
)

-- Reputation split. THIS is the schema expression of the $8 correction.
provider_reliability (          -- ONE row per provider: portable
  provider_id PK, on_time_rate, completion_rate, response_time_s,
  dispute_rate, cancellation_rate, integrity_score,
  score, confidence_lower, sample_size, computed_at
)
provider_category_competence (  -- ONE row per provider PER CATEGORY: never portable
  provider_id, category_id, jobs_completed, quality_rating,
  rework_rate, first_time_right, assessment_score,
  score, confidence_lower, PRIMARY KEY (provider_id, category_id)
)

-- Gate: a provider may only be offered in a category they are cleared for.
provider_category_clearance (
  provider_id, category_id, tier, cleared_at, cleared_by, expires_at,
  evidence_ref, PRIMARY KEY (provider_id, category_id)
)

evidence_asset (
  id, transaction_id, scope_item_id, type,
  captured_in_app boolean NOT NULL,      -- false is disqualifying for tier 3
  captured_at, geo geography(Point), accuracy_m,
  content_hash, perceptual_hash, storage_ref
)

location (id, country, county, town, ward, geo geography(Point), parent_id)
travel_time (from_ward_id, to_ward_id, hour_of_day, seconds) -- NOT straight-line
```

### REC Six schema rules, each expensive to retrofit:

1. **Money is** `amount_minor bigint + currency`. Never a float.
2. **materials\_amount\_minor is structurally separate from service\_amount\_minor**. It is a liability pass-through and must never enter GMV or revenue.
3. **The ledger is append-only**. Corrections are reversing entries.
4. **Reputation is derived from transaction\_event, never authored**. Lets you change the formula and recompute history — which you will do at least twice.
5. **provider\_category\_clearance is enforced in the query layer, not in application logic**. A provider without clearance must be *unable* to surface in that category. This is a safety control expressed as a constraint.

6. **Location is a hierarchy plus geography plus a travel-time matrix.** "Kilimani" as a string makes dispatch impossible.

---

## State machines

One spine, mode-specific stages, as specified in 04. **REC Implement as a table-driven state machine, not a switch statement:** `(from_state, event, fulfilment_mode) → to_state + guards + side_effects`. New verticals add rows, not branches. This is the concrete answer to your brief's warning about one unmaintainable giant machine.

Every transition writes an immutable `transaction_event` with an idempotency key.

---

## The ops console (Brief §53)

**REC This is a primary product, not internal tooling, and it should be staffed in the first sprint.** V0 and V1 are manually operated marketplaces; the console is the operating surface of the company.

**Day-one requirements:** live job board by state with SLA breach highlighting · provider verification queue with document review · **report/evidence QC queue** (every report reviewed before the customer sees it) · manual assignment and reassignment · dispute workspace showing both sides' evidence and the full event timeline · payment operations (retry payout, manual release, refund, reconciliation breaks) · **incident log with escalation** · provider and customer 360 views.

**REC Two things founders consistently under-build and regret:** the **reconciliation break queue** (payment discrepancies compound silently and surface at the worst moment) and the **incident log** (safety events need a documented, timestamped, reviewable trail from the first one, not the first serious one).

---

## AI — position unchanged (Brief §39)

**REC LLMs interpret and draft. Deterministic code decides money, ranking, reputation, clearance and disputes.** Unchanged from the original blueprint and more important now, because the decisions carry physical and financial consequence.

| Version | AI role                                                                                                                                   |
|---------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| MVP     | <b>None.</b> Ops reads free-text requests and structures them by hand.                                                                    |
| V2      | LLM structures intake into a <code>ServiceTransaction</code> draft — always human-reviewed before dispatch. Trained on the manual corpus. |
| V3      | Learned ranking on completed-job outcomes; demand forecasting for supply planning.                                                        |

**REC Never let a model decide who is dispatched to a customer's home, or whether a provider is cleared for a category.** Those are deterministic, auditable, testable decisions — and the ones you will have to defend.

# Metrics and Marketplace KPIs

## North Star

### Completed, protected transactions per month

**governed by two guardrails: average job value and repeat rate**

**Definition:** transactions reaching **SETTLED** — evidence accepted, customer satisfied, provider paid — in a calendar month.

**REC Why this and not GMV.** GMV is distorted by a handful of large jobs and says nothing about whether the marketplace works. A completed protected transaction cannot happen unless a customer trusted you, a provider delivered, evidence satisfied, and money moved. Every failure mode in the business reduces it. And it is legible to everyone from an engineer to an ops associate to a provider.

**REC Why the guardrails are mandatory.** Optimising the count alone drives toward small, cheap jobs — precisely the sub-KSh 5,000 categories the strategy excludes. And growth from new customers only is a treadmill.

**The board line, every month:**

**"N jobs completed, at KSh X average, Y% from returning customers."**

## The metric that decides whether this is a company

**REC Repeat rate at 90 days.** Your brief says one-off transactions can be manufactured but habit cannot be faked. Correct — and in this business it is *the* number, because **FACT** lead-gen marketplaces show repeat rates as low as 15%, Handy struggled to exceed 2:1 LTV:CAC, and TaskRabbit's ~4:1 came from retention.

$$\text{Repeat rate (90d)} = \frac{\text{customers with } \geq 2 \text{ settled jobs within 90 days}}{\text{customers with } \geq 1 \text{ settled job}}$$

**REC Targets: >30% by month 3, >40% by month 12.** Below 25% at month 6 means you are running a services agency with an app, and the response is to stop building and find out why.

## Core metrics and formulas

### Volume and value

GMV =  $\sum$  service\_amount of settled transactions  
     $\Delta$  EXCLUDES materials pass-through  
Net revenue = platform fees – payment costs – refunds  
AOV = GMV / settled transactions  
Take rate = platform fees / GMV  
GMV per customer/yr = AOV  $\times$  jobs/yr  $\times$  retention       $\leftarrow$  the pricing objective

### Marketplace health

Active providers =  $\geq 1$  accepted job in 30d  
Earning providers =  $\geq 1$  SETTLED job in 30d       $\leftarrow$  track this, not signups  
Provider utilisation = earning providers / verified providers  
Fill rate = jobs assigned & accepted / jobs requested  
Time to assignment = median request  $\rightarrow$  provider accepted      target <2h  
Time to completion = median funded  $\rightarrow$  settled  
Coverage depth = verified providers per service per ward      target  $\geq 5$

**REC** Coverage depth per ward is the density metric that governs expansion. Below 5, response times slip and the product feels broken locally.

### Trust and quality

Completion rate = settled / funded      target >92%  
First-time-right = approved without rework / approved      target >85%  
Dispute rate = disputes / funded      target <3%  
Auto-approve rate = approved by timeout / approved      watch: disengagement  
Evidence rejection = evidence returned as insufficient      watch: provider training  
Median time to payout = settled\_at – approved\_at      target <60 min  
Safety incidents = absolute count      target 0, reviewed individually

**REC** Safety incidents are never a rate. Report the number and review each one.

### Efficiency

Cost to serve = (ops + support + T&S + payment costs) / settled transactions  
     $\leftarrow$  must fall every quarter or Scenario 3 never arrives  
CAC per side = attributable S&M / newly activated customers (or providers)  
LTV (customer) = AOV  $\times$  jobs/yr  $\times$  years  $\times$  contribution margin  
LTV:CAC > 3.0 by month 18  
Contribution per job = revenue – payment cost – cost to serve       $\leftarrow$  positive by month 9

## The dashboard that should exist

**REC** Six numbers on one screen. If a seventh is needed, something is wrong.

|                       |           |       |              |
|-----------------------|-----------|-------|--------------|
| Completed jobs (mo)   | 412       | ▲ 18% |              |
| Average job value     | KSh 8,240 | ▲ 4%  | △ guardrail  |
| Repeat rate (90d)     | 34%       | ▲ 3pt | △ guardrail  |
| Contribution per job  | KSh 410   | ▲     |              |
| Median time to payout | 38 min    | ✓     |              |
| Disputes              | 2.1%      | ✓     | Incidents: 0 |

## Vanity metrics to refuse

**REC** Ban these from internal reporting, however good they look to investors:

| Metric                  | Why it misleads                                          |
|-------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| Registered providers    | Will be 10–20× earning providers. Meaningless.           |
| Registered customers    | Same.                                                    |
| App downloads           | No app, and it would not matter.                         |
| GMV including materials | <b>Inflates the number with money that is not yours.</b> |
| Jobs <i>requested</i>   | Only completed jobs count.                               |
| Categories live         | Breadth is the failure mode, not the achievement.        |
| Cities covered          | Density beats coverage.                                  |

**REC** The last two deserve emphasis, because they are exactly the numbers a horizontal-marketplace narrative reaches for — and celebrating them is how a company talks itself into the strategy that killed its predecessors.

# Risks and Regulatory Surface

## The twenty ways this fails

Ordered by probability × severity. **REC** The first five are the ones that actually decide the outcome.

- 1. You launch horizontally and reach liquidity in nothing.** *Evidence:* **FACT** Lynk pivoted operating models repeatedly across dozens of categories and exited via acquisition; SweepSouth spent \$15M+ and left Kenya. *Prevention:* one vertical, one corridor, gated expansion. *Warning:* a second category opening before the first hits 300 jobs/month. *Mitigation:* close categories, do not add them.
- 2. The diaspora wedge is not real — willingness to pay does not exist at scale.** *Prevention:* the 30-day validation in **11** before building. *Warning:* fewer than 10 unsolicited payers in week 2. *Mitigation:* fall back to Vertical 2, where a complete blueprint and a proven buyer already exist. **REC** **This fallback is the reason not to delete the creator work.**
- 3. Cost to serve never falls below contribution per job.** *Prevention:* KSh 5,000 floor; productisation; measure per-job cost from month one. *Warning:* cost to serve flat for two quarters. *Mitigation:* raise prices or narrow the catalogue — never chase volume at negative contribution.
- 4. Agency fraud — an inspector is bribed and a customer loses life savings.** *Prevention:* structured evidence, in-app capture, dual coverage on high-value jobs, outcome follow-up, conflict declarations (06). *Warning:* any single instance. *Mitigation:* make the customer whole immediately, publish what happened, tighten. **REC** **This is the failure mode that ends the company rather than damaging it.**
- 5. A safety incident in a customer's home, or to a provider.** *Prevention:* tiered verification, check-in/out, provider opt-in rules, incident protocol written before launch. *Warning:* any report. *Mitigation:* founder-level response within hours.
- 6. Disintermediation in the categories you do launch.** *Prevention:* wedge selection (09), descending repeat fees, Deal Desk, guarantees. *Warning:* per-pair repeat below 20%.
- 7. Supply vetting costs more than modelled.** *Evidence:* **FACT** Lynk had to build an academy after training partnerships failed. *Prevention:* launch vertical needs integrity and documentation, not trade skill. *Warning:* cost per cleared provider above KSh 5,000.
- 8. Providers cannot use the software.** *Prevention:* offline-tolerant capture, WhatsApp-first comms, in-person onboarding. *Warning:* evidence rejection rate above 20%.
- 9. Frequency is too low to build habit.** *Prevention:* the landlord conversion and recurring series. *Warning:* repeat below 25% at month 6.
- 10. Existing players (Kalinoi, Balozy, My-Fundi) move first on verification.** *Prevention:* depth in one vertical beats their breadth. *Warning:* any launches a diaspora inspection product. *Mitigation:* compete on evidence quality and guarantee, not features.
- 11. A well-funded entrant.** *Mitigation:* **FACT** SweepSouth proves capability does not travel; local operational depth is the defence.
- 12. Regulatory action on holding funds.** *Prevention:* aggregator architecture, 60-day escrow cap, written opinion pre-launch.

**13. Classification of providers as employees.** *Prevention:* genuine contractor structure; domestic work excluded. **LEGAL — COUNSEL REQUIRED**

**14. Property representation strays into regulated estate-agency or legal advice.** *Prevention:* report facts and evidence only; never opinion on title, valuation or legality; never hold deposits.

**LEGAL — COUNSEL REQUIRED**

**15. Payment or reconciliation failure destroys trust.** *Prevention:* double-entry from commit one, daily reconciliation, a named owner. *Mitigation:* **pay from platform funds first, investigate second.**

**16. Founder-led sales does not transfer to hires.** *Prevention:* document every objection from job one.

**17. Building before selling.** *Prevention:* 60 manual jobs before the MVP. *Warning:* engineering velocity high, GMV flat.

**18. Provider concentration** — a handful of providers carry most jobs and can hold you up. *Prevention:* monitor share; cap at 15%.

**19. Data protection breach involving ID documents and home addresses.** *Prevention:* consider a specialist KYC vendor so you hold verification results rather than raw documents; encrypt; strict access; ODPC registration.

**20. The founders solve the interesting problem instead of the boring one.** *Prevention:* North Star is completed jobs, not features. **REC** In this business the boring problem is recruiting twelve honest people and checking their reports. That is the company.

## Regulatory surface (Brief §66)

**REC** Nothing here is legal advice. The pivot materially widens the surface relative to the creator marketplace, and four items below are new.

### Resolve before taking money

| # | Question                                                                                         | Status                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|---|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 | Does the escrow architecture make us a PSP requiring CBK authorisation?                          | Carried over — <b>FACT</b> PSP licensing required for processing retail payments, operating wallets or aggregating, under NPS Act 2011 / NPS Regulations 2014, with client-fund segregation obligations |
| 2 | <b>Are providers unambiguously independent contractors?</b>                                      | <b>New and sharper</b> — physical, scheduled, supervised-feeling work invites scrutiny that remote creator work did not                                                                                 |
| 3 | <b>Does property inspection/representation touch estate-agency or legal-practice regulation?</b> | <b>New</b>                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| 4 | Withholding tax and VAT by service type                                                          | <b>FACT</b> The 5% digital-content-monetisation regime applies to the creator vertical; treatment of trade labour, inspection fees, platform fees and materials pass-through is a different question    |



| # | Question                                                                  | Status                                                                                                                                                                                             |
|---|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 5 | ODPC registration                                                         | <b>FACT</b> Registration required under the Data Protection Act 2019; thresholds include turnover above KSh 5M, >10 employees, or processing sensitive data; penalties to KSh 5M or 1% of turnover |
| 6 | <b>Consumer protection obligations for a platform making trust claims</b> | <b>New</b> — "verified" is a representation to consumers                                                                                                                                           |

## New exposures created by the pivot

**Domestic work.** **FACT** Gazetted minimum wage of **KSh 18,047/month** in the major cities (KSh 9,268 in smaller towns and rural areas); over two million domestic workers, largely informal and on verbal agreements. **REC Excluded from the plan** — but if it is ever reconsidered, the classification and wage-compliance analysis must come first, not after.

**Physical safety and liability.** Sending people into homes creates duty-of-care questions and insurance requirements the creator marketplace never had. **REC Obtain public liability and professional indemnity cover before the first on-site job**, and be precise in the product about what any "guarantee" actually covers.

**Trust claims as consumer representations.** **REC Every badge in 06 must be substantiable.** Do not use "background checked." **LEGAL — COUNSEL REQUIRED** on the lawful basis for collecting and retaining Certificates of Good Conduct.

**Data protection, sharpened.** You will hold national IDs, liveness selfies, home addresses, geotagged photographs of people's homes, and reports about their property. **REC Provider home addresses and customer property addresses are the most sensitive data in the system.** Address is released only after funding and assignment; evidence photographs of interiors are access-controlled and retained under a documented policy; and the tension between financial-record retention and erasure rights must be resolved in writing with counsel.

**Cross-border.** Diaspora customers mean processing personal data of people in the UK, US, EU and Gulf. **REC Confirm the position on inbound customers under UK/EU regimes** — it may be limited, but it should be answered rather than assumed.

## Checklist

**Before first shilling:** incorporation and KRA PIN · **PSP opinion** · **contractor-classification opinion** · **property-representation opinion** · ODPC registration · terms, provider agreement, privacy notice · aggregator contract · **public liability and professional indemnity insurance** · substantiated definitions for every trust badge · incident-response protocol · principal-vs-agent decision documented.

**Before scale:** VAT assessment · trust-account structure · formal data-retention policy · category-specific legal review before each new vertical.

**REC Budget KSh 1.2-2.0M for pre-launch legal, tax, compliance and insurance.** **ASSUMPTION** — higher than the creator marketplace estimate because the surface is genuinely wider. In a business whose entire proposition is trust, a compliance or safety failure is not a legal problem; it is an extinction event.

# Brand, Defensibility, Investor Case

## Brand (Brief \$44)

**REC** "Flerwa" no longer fits, and the reason is specific rather than aesthetic. It is a good invented name — short, trademarkable, no baggage. But an invented word carries no meaning, which means the *descriptor* does all the work. For a creator marketplace with one audience that was fine. For a platform where a frightened nurse in Manchester must decide in ten seconds whether to trust you with a decision worth six figures of shillings, **a meaningless name makes the trust job harder**, and you will pay for it in every conversion funnel.

**REC** What the brand must do:

| Requirement                                                   | Why                                     |
|---------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| Say <i>safety</i> before it says <i>convenience</i>           | The customer is buying relief from fear |
| Work for a nurse in Manchester <b>and</b> a fundi in Kasarani | Two audiences, one word                 |
| Not sound like a creator platform, or a cleaning app          | It must survive three verticals         |
| Feel Kenyan without being untranslatable across East Africa   | Expansion                               |
| Be sayable over a noisy phone line                            | Most referrals are spoken               |

**Naming directions, with honest assessment:**

| Direction                               | Examples                                                                               | Assessment                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|-----------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Swahili trust/verification roots</b> | <i>Hakika</i> (certainty), <i>Thibiti</i> (verify/confirm), <i>Uhakika</i> (assurance) | <b>REC Strongest.</b> Meaning does the work; local without being parochial; travels across East Africa. <b>Verify availability and connotation with native speakers — I cannot assess nuance reliably.</b> |
| Representation / agency                 | <i>Mwakilishi</i> (representative)                                                     | Accurate but long, and already a diaspora media brand — <b>FACT</b> mwakilishi.com is an existing Kenyan diaspora news site. Avoid.                                                                        |
| Plain-English descriptive               | <i>Trusted</i> , <i>Verified</i> , <i>Vouched</i>                                      | Clear but generic, hard to trademark, and hard to own                                                                                                                                                      |
| Invented (status quo)                   | <i>Flerwa</i>                                                                          | Ownable, meaningless; makes the trust job harder                                                                                                                                                           |

**REC** Positioning, whichever name is chosen:

### Know before you pay.

**Verified people in Kenya who will go, look, and tell you the truth — for anything you can't be there for. Money held safely until the job is done.**

That headline works for the launch product, extends to fundi work ("know what it should cost before you pay"), and survives into Vertical 2. **REC** The generic version — "Whatever you need done, find

someone you can trust" — is the *company line for later*. Do not lead with it at launch; it describes a marketplace you have not yet earned.

**REC Before any public use:** trademark search at KIPI, domain and handles, and a native-speaker review for unintended meaning in Swahili, Sheng and major vernaculars.

## Defensibility, honestly (Brief §68)

**REC Rank your candidate moats by whether they survive a well-funded competitor arriving tomorrow.**

| Claimed moat                                                 | Real?           | Assessment                                                                                                                                                                 |
|--------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| "Trust" as a positioning                                     | No              | Every competitor claims it. It is table stakes, not a moat.                                                                                                                |
| Escrow + M-Pesa                                              | No              | Any team can build this in a quarter                                                                                                                                       |
| The transaction primitive / architecture                     | No              | Good engineering, copyable                                                                                                                                                 |
| AI matching                                                  | No              | Commodity                                                                                                                                                                  |
| Vetted supply in a specific vertical and corridor            | Yes, moderately | <b>FACT</b> Lynk's academy and Urban Company's training are the evidence: supply quality is expensive and slow, and it is where value creation actually sits               |
| Operational competence at evidence QC and dispute resolution | Yes             | Boring, unglamorous, takes years, does not transfer between companies                                                                                                      |
| Local density                                                | Yes, locally    | <b>FACT</b> SweepSouth's exit shows capability does not travel — protects you at home, constrains your expansion equally                                                   |
| Accumulated verified transaction record                      | Yes, eventually | <b>FACT</b> Kandua's exit to an insurer after building embedded financial services is the evidence this pools value — but it is a <i>consequence</i> of years of operation |
| Brand as the default verb                                    | Yes, if earned  | The real prize, and the slowest                                                                                                                                            |

**REC The honest summary for any investor conversation:** *"There is no moat on day one. The moat is the ten thousandth completed job, the supply pool we vetted to get there, and the operational discipline that made it repeatable. Anyone who tells you their trust marketplace has a moat at launch is selling."*

**REC On "the ledger is the moat" (your §14):** revised. The verified record of real-world work is a genuine long-term asset — **FACT** the Kandua outcome demonstrates it. But it is not a strategy you can execute toward. Build for liquidity in one vertical; the record accumulates as a by-product. **A company that optimises for the dataset before it has liquidity gets neither.** And keep lending, insurance and underwriting out of the fundraising narrative until the regulatory and risk analysis your own brief calls for has actually been done.

## The investor case (Brief \$67)

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### The narrative

**Why now.** **FACT** Kenya moves ~US\$5B/year in remittances, and fraud against distant buyers is documented and worsening — housing scams surging across Nairobi's prime estates, diaspora investors targeted specifically because distance makes due diligence impossible. Mobile money makes remote payment for local work trivial. The infrastructure to act on someone's behalf, verifiably, does not exist.

**Why this wedge.** We start where trust is worth the most per shilling, not where it is cheapest to serve. Our customer earns hard currency, already sends money blind, and has no local network they can rely on — which is why they cannot route around us.

**Why us, why not the graveyard.** **FACT** Lynk and SweepSouth both attempted horizontal home services in Nairobi and neither reached escape velocity. We have read their post-mortems and drawn the opposite conclusion: one vertical, above KSh 5,000, verified deeply, in one corridor.

**What it becomes.** The same verified supply, transaction rail and reputation record extends to business services and high-value trade work. **FACT** The realised outcome for the best-run African comparable was acquisition by an insurer — evidence of where value pools when you own the verified-work relationship.

### The questions you will be asked, and the honest answers

**"Isn't this just Lynk again?"** No — and **FACT** Lynk's own lessons are why. They went horizontal across dozens of categories, ran an auction model they later abandoned, and carried heavy trade-vetting costs. We launch in one vertical, fixed-price, with supply selected for integrity rather than trade skill, above a hard price floor.

**"What's the market size?"** **REC** Answer honestly, and lead with the honesty. *"The measured comparables are small and I won't inflate them. What we can prove cheaply is willingness to pay, and here is the 30-day test with a written kill criterion."* An investor who has seen manufactured TAMs will find this more credible than a large number, not less.

**"Why won't they go around you?"** Because the customer has no relationship to fall back on — the absence of one is why they came. Contrast with cleaning, where they leak by week three, which is why we are not in cleaning.

**"What happens outside Nairobi?"** Slower and later. **FACT** SweepSouth's exit shows this capability does not travel cheaply. We would rather own one corridor than sprinkle six.

**"Is trust defensible?"** Not as a claim. As accumulated supply, operational competence and record — yes, slowly. See above.

## Final recommendation (Brief §69)

### The answer to your closing question

**If we execute this correctly, is there a potentially much larger company here than the original creator marketplace?**

**Yes — but not the company you described, and the reason matters.**

The creator marketplace was capped by market size: **FACT** a US\$2.1–3.0M measured Kenyan influencer market supports perhaps \$200–400k of annual revenue at full capture. That ceiling is real and unfixable.

**The horizontal trusted-services marketplace is not obviously larger, because it does not survive contact with the constraints.** It carries lower average value, worse leakage, five supply problems instead of one, physical safety exposure, and two funded predecessors who failed at it in this exact city. **FACT** Lynk pivoted repeatedly and exited by acquisition; SweepSouth spent \$15M+ and left. Breadth is not the path to scale here — it is the mechanism of failure.

**What is genuinely larger is the third thing: a deep vertical business built on a reusable trust primitive**, starting where the trust deficit is most acute and most expensive — the remote principal — and extending along the property lifecycle into trade work and business services. That business: - has average job values 2–4× the categories in your brief, clearing the KSh 5,000 line; - is structurally leakage-resistant, because the customer's problem *is* the absence of a trusted relationship; - serves a hard-currency buyer already accustomed to paying for unverifiable outcomes; - accumulates exactly the verified record that **FACT** proved valuable enough for an insurer to acquire Kandua; - and keeps your existing creator blueprint intact as Vertical 2 and as the validated fallback.

**It is larger than the creator marketplace. It is larger than the horizontal marketplace. And it is the only one of the three with an honest path from month one to month thirty-six.**

### The business I recommend you actually build

**A verification and representation service for people who cannot be in Kenya to protect their own money — starting with property, in the Nairobi corridor, with fixed prices, escrowed payment, structured evidence and deeply vetted providers.**

**Then the same trusted people, the same rail and the same record, extended to the work that property generates and the businesses that grow around it.**

**The first ten things to build:** escrow with M-Pesa · structured evidence capture with in-app geotagging · the four productised services · the transaction spine with all timers, especially 5-day auto-approve · append-only event log and double-entry ledger · the ops console with a report QC queue · provider verification tiers with per-category clearance · provider storefronts · the Deal Desk at 5% · WhatsApp notifications with a shareable payout receipt.

**The first ten things not to build:** native apps · more than four services · AI matching or intake · post-a-task bidding · quote-based work · materials escrow · recurring billing automation · background-check automation · insurance or lending · any second city.

**The one number that decides everything: repeat rate at 90 days.** Below 25% at month six, this is a services agency with an app, and the right response is to stop building and find out why.

**And the one thing to do before any of it:** the 30-day, KSh 150,000 validation in 11. **FACT** Lynk spent seven years and SweepSouth spent \$15M+ learning things that a month of real customer money would have surfaced. Buy that answer cheaply.

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# Sources

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Research conducted **8 September 2026**. Every **FACT** traces to a source below. Where I could not verify something, the document says so rather than smoothing over it.

## The Kenyan graveyard — the most important sources here

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- **Lynk: The Flip** — "Lynk: Lessons Learned The Hard Way" · Jobtech Alliance — shifting from an auction marketplace to a standardised service model · WeeTracker — Eden Life acquires Lynk · How We Made It In Africa — Adam Grunewald interview · StartupList Africa
- **SweepSouth: TechCabal** — inside the decision to close Nigeria and Kenya · Capital FM · TechTrends KE
- **Kenyan startup failures generally:** Business Tech Africa

## African comparables

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- **Kandua:** PitchBook — acquired by Santam, May 2024 · BFA Global — embedded financial services thesis · Knife Capital
- **Eden Life:** PitchBook · Tech In Africa — rebrand toward e-commerce

## Global service marketplace models

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- Oyelabs — TaskRabbit vs Thumbtack vs Handy (LTV:CAC figures, lead-gen repeat rates)
- Airtasker FY2026 earnings call · Airtasker Q3 2026
- Thumbtack business model · Thumbtack lead costs by trade
- **Urban Company:** Arthnova — scaling India's home services market · Markhub24 — the managed marketplace model · White Ocean

## Kenya market, diaspora and trust deficit

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- **Remittances:** Business Daily — CBK sees remittances reaching Sh676bn in 2026 · The Star · Trading Economics
- **Property and rental fraud:** Citizen Digital — housing scams surge in Nairobi's prime estates · Daily Nation — faces behind diaspora home-buying scams · Mwakilishi — diaspora investors defrauded · Huduma Global — scams targeting the diaspora · BuyRentKenya · Tenantt
- **Domestic work:** Daily Nation — house-help minimum wage Sh18,047 · Kudheihia · Gig-economy regulation in Kenya (BMZ) · DLA Piper Africa — gig worker labour rights
- **Current Kenyan operators:** My-Fundi · Balozy · Kalinoi · Juakali Hub

## Carried over from the creator-marketplace research

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Payments and regulation (CBK PSP licensing, Daraja, M-Pesa tariffs), tax (5% digital content withholding), data protection (ODPC), Kenyan digital population and advertising market sizing, and all creator-platform competitive research are cited in full in [archive-creator-marketplace/sources.md](#).

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## Caveats on source quality

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**REC** Treat this as a well-researched starting point, not verified market intelligence.

- **The single most important source — The Flip's Lynk post-mortem — could not be fetched directly** (blocked by the network egress proxy). Its findings here come from search excerpts and corroborating coverage. **Read the original before finalising strategy; it is the closest thing to a map of this exact minefield.**
- **Competitor scale is unverified.** I could not establish transaction volume, funding or team size for My-Fundi, Balozy, Kalinoi or Juakali Hub. Their public presence suggests early stage, but **sign up and transact on each before finalising positioning** — desk research cannot distinguish a real marketplace from a directory with a booking form.
- **The diaspora willingness-to-pay assumption is unverified by any source.** It is the load-bearing assumption of the recommended strategy and the reason [11](#) opens with a 30-day validation and a written kill criterion.
- **All Kenyan prices in this document are placeholders.** None is market data.
- **Unit-cost inputs are estimates** and must be replaced with real aggregator and staffing quotes.
- **Nothing here is legal, tax or financial advice.** Items marked **LEGAL — COUNSEL REQUIRED** are a briefing for a Kenyan advocate, not a substitute for one.